

dào dé jīng
道 德 經
way virtue classic

Dao De Jing

Chapter 1

dào kě dào fēi cháng dào
道 可 道 非 常 道
way can speak not constant way

míng kě míng fēi cháng míng
名 可 名 非 常 名
name can named not constant name

wú míng tiān dì zhī shǐ
無 名 天 地 之 始
without name heaven earth of beginning

yǒu míng wàn wù zhī mǔ
有 名 萬 物 之 母
having name ten-thousand things of mother

gù cháng wú yù yǐ guān qí miào
故 常 無 欲 以 觀 其 妙
therefore constant without desire by-means-of observe its mystery

cháng yǒu yù yǐ guān qí jiào
常 有 欲 以 觀 其 徼
constant having desire by-means-of observe its boundary

cǐ liǎng zhě tóng chū ér yì míng
此 兩 者 同 出 而 異 名
these two ones same emerge yet different name

tóng wèi zhī xuán
同 謂 之 玄
together called it dark-mystery

xuán zhī yòu xuán
玄 之 又 玄
dark-mystery of further dark-mystery

zhòng miào zhī mén
眾 妙 之 門
many mysteries of gateway

The Way that can be spoken is not the eternal Way.
The name that can be named is not the eternal name.
The nameless is the origin of heaven and earth.
The named is the mother of ten thousand things.
Therefore, constantly without desire, one observes its mysteries.
Constantly with desire, one observes its manifestations.
These two emerge together but have different names.
Together they are called mystery.
Mystery of mysteries.
The gateway to all mysteries.

Chapter 2

tiān xià jiē zhī měi zhī wéi měi sī è
天下 皆 知 美 之 為 美 斯 惡
under-heaven all know beauty of become beauty then ugly
yǐ
已
already

jiē zhī shàn zhī wéi shàn sī bù shàn
皆 知 善 之 為 善 斯 不 善
all know good of become good then not good
yǐ
已
already

gù yǒu wú xiāng shēng
故 有 無 相 生
therefore have not-have mutually generate

nán yì xiāng chéng
難 易 相 成
difficult easy mutually complete

cháng duǎn xiāng jiào
長 短 相 較
long short mutually compare

gāo	xià	xiāng	qīng
高	下	相	傾
high	low	mutually	incline

yīn	shēng	xiāng	hé
音	聲	相	和
tone	sound	mutually	harmonize

qián	hòu	xiāng	suí
前	後	相	隨
front	back	mutually	follow

shì	yǐ	shèng	rén
是	以	聖	人
this	by-means-of	sage	person

chù	wú wéi	zhī	shì
處	無為	之	事
dwelt	non-action	of	affairs

xíng	bù	yán	zhī	jiào
行	不	言	之	教
practice	not	speak	of	teaching

wàn	wù	zuò	—	ér	bù	shǐ
萬	物	作	—	而	不	始
ten-thousand	things	arise		yet	not	initiate

shēng	ér	bù	yǒu
生	而	不	有
create	yet	not	have

wéi	ér	bù	shì
為	而	不	恃
act	yet	not	rely

gōng	chéng	ér	fú	jū
功	成	而	弗	居
merit	complete	yet	not	dwell

fú	wéi	fú	jū
夫	唯	弗	居
indeed	only	not	dwell

shì	yǐ	bù	qù
是	以	不	去
this	by-means-of	not	leave

All under heaven know beauty as beauty, thus ugliness exists.
All know good as good, thus not-good exists.
Therefore being and non-being give birth to each other.
Difficult and easy complement each other.
Long and short contrast each other.
High and low lean upon each other.
Voice and sound harmonize with each other.
Front and back follow each other.
Therefore the sage
Dwells in affairs of non-action
Practices teaching without words
Ten thousand things arise but he does not initiate
Creates but does not possess
Acts but does not rely
Accomplishes but does not dwell
Only because he does not dwell
Therefore it does not leave

Chapter 3

bù	shàng	xián
不	尚	賢
not	exalt	worthy

shǐ	mín	bù	zhēng
使	民	不	爭
cause	people	not	compete

bù	guì	nán	dé	zhī	huò
不	貴	難	得	之	貨
not	value	difficult	obtain	of	goods

shǐ	mín	bù	wéi	dào
使	民	不	為	盜
cause	people	not	become	thief

bù	jiàn	kě	yù
不	見	可	欲
not	show	can	desire

shǐ	mín	xīn	bù	luàn
使	民	心	不	亂
cause	people	heart	not	chaos

shì yǐ shèng rén zhī zhì
是 以 聖 人 之 治
this by-means-of sage person of govern

xū qí xīn shí qí fù
虛 其 心 實 其 腹
empty their heart fill their belly

ruò qí zhì qiáng qí gǔ
弱 其 志 強 其 骨
weaken their will strengthen their bone

cháng shǐ mín wú zhī wú yù
常 使 民 無 知 無 欲
always cause people without knowledge without desire

shǐ fū zhì zhě bù gǎn wéi —
使 夫 智 者 不 敢 為 —
cause those wise ones not dare act

wéi wú wéi zé wú bù zhì yǐ
為 無 為 則 無 不 治 矣
do nothing do then nothing not order indeed

Do not exalt the talented
So the people will not compete
Do not value rare treasures
So the people will not steal
Do not display what is desirable
So the people's hearts will not be disturbed
Therefore the sage governs by
Emptying their hearts and filling their bellies
Weakening their ambitions and strengthening their bones
Always keeping the people without knowledge and without desire
Causing the clever ones to not dare to act
Practice non-action and everything will be in order

Chapter 4

dào	zhōng	ér	yòng	zhī	yǒu	bù	yíng
道	盅	而	用	之	有	不	盈
way	empty	yet	use	it	exist	not	full

yuān	xī	sì	wàn	wù	zhī	zōng
淵	兮	似	萬	物	之	宗
deep	!	like	ten-thousand	things	of	ancestor

cuò	qí	ruì
挫	其	銳
blunt	its	sharp

jiě	qí	fēn
解	其	紛
untie	its	tangled

hé	qí	guāng
和	其	光
harmonize	its	light

tóng	qí	chén
同	其	塵
unite	its	dust

zhàn xī sì huò cún
湛 兮 似 或 存
deep-clear ! like perhaps exist

wú bù zhī shuí zhī zǐ
吾 不 知 誰 之 子
I not know who of child

xiàng dì zhī xiān
象 帝 之 先
appear emperor of before

The Dao is empty, yet its use is inexhaustible.
Deep and profound, it seems to be the ancestor of all things.
Blunt the sharpness.
Untangle the knots.
Soften the glare.
Merge with the dust.
Deep and clear, it seems to exist.
I do not know whose child it is.
It appears to precede the Emperor.

Chapter 5

tiān dì bù rén
天 地 不 仁
heaven earth not benevolent

yǐ wàn wù wéi chú gǒu
以 萬 物 為 芻狗
by-means-of ten-thousand things make straw-dogs

shèng rén bù rén
聖 人 不 仁
sage person not benevolent

yǐ bǎi xìng wéi chú gǒu
以 百 姓 為 芻狗
by-means-of hundred surnames make straw-dogs

tiān dì zhī jiān
天 地 之 間
heaven earth of between

qí yóu tuó yuè hū
其 猶 橐籥 乎
its like bellows question

xū	ér	bù	qū
虛	而	不	屈
empty	yet	not	bend

dòng	ér	yù	chū
動	而	愈	出
move	yet	more	produce

duō	yán	shuò	qióng
多	言	數	窮
much	speech	count	exhaust

bù	rú	shǒu	zhōng
不	如	守	中
not	like	keep	center

Heaven and Earth are not humane
They treat the ten thousand things as straw dogs
The sage is not humane
And treats the hundred families as straw dogs
Between Heaven and Earth
Is it not like a bellows?
Empty yet inexhaustible
Moving, it yields more and more
Much talk leads to swift exhaustion
Better to maintain the center

Chapter 6

gǔ shén bù sǐ
谷 神 不 死
valley spirit not die

shì wèi xuán pī
是 謂 玄 牝
this called mysterious female

xuán pī zhī mén
玄 牝 之 門
mysterious female of gateway

shì wèi tiān dì zhī gēn
是 謂 天 地 之 根
this called heaven earth of root

mián mián ruò cún
綿 綿 若 存
continuous continuous like exist

yòng zhī bù qín
用 之 不 勤
use it not toil

The valley spirit never dies.
This is called the mysterious feminine.
The gateway of the mysterious feminine,
Is called the root of heaven and earth.
Continuous, seeming to persist,
Its use never exhausted.

Chapter 7

tiān cháng dì jiǔ
天 長 地 久
heaven lasting earth enduring

tiān dì suǒyǐ néng cháng qiě jiǔ zhě
天 地 所以 能 長 且 久 者
heaven earth reason-why can lasting and enduring one-who

yǐ qí bù zì shēng
以 其 不 自 生
by-means-of their not self live

gù néng cháng shēng
故 能 長 生
therefore can long live

shì yǐ shèng rén
是 以 聖 人
this thus sage person

hòu qí shēn ér shēn xiān
後 其 身 而 身 先
behind their body yet body ahead

wài	qí	shēn	ér	shēn	cún
外	其	身	而	身	存
outside	their	body	yet	body	exists

fēi	yǐ	qí	wú	sī	xié
非	以	其	無	私	邪
is-not	by-means-of	their	without	private	question

gù	néng	chéng	qí	sī
故	能	成	其	私
therefore	can	accomplish	their	private

Heaven is lasting and Earth enduring.
The reason Heaven and Earth can be lasting and enduring is
Because they do not live for themselves.
Thus they can live long.
Therefore the sage:
Puts self last but ends up in front.
Puts self outside but self remains.
Is it not because they have no self-interest?
Therefore they can fulfill their own interests.

Chapter 8

shàng	shàn	ruò	shuǐ
上	善	若	水
highest	excellence	like	water

shuǐ	shàn	lì	wàn	wù	ér	bù	zhēng
水	善	利	萬	物	而	不	爭
water	good-at	benefit	ten-thousand	things	yet	not	strive

chǔ	zhòng	rén	zhī	suǒ	wù
處	眾	人	之	所	惡
dwelt	many	people	of	that-which	reject

gù	jī	yú	dào	
故	幾	於	道	矣
therefore	near	to	way	indeed

jū	shàn	dì
居	善	地
dwelling	excel-in	place

xīn	shàn	yuān
心	善	淵
mind	excel-in	depth

yǔ	shàn	rén
與	善	仁
giving	excel-in	benevolence

yán	shàn	xìn
言	善	信
speech	excel-in	truth

zhèng	shàn	zhì
正	善	治
govern	excel-in	order

shì	shàn	néng
事	善	能
affairs	excel-in	ability

dòng	shàn	shí
動	善	時
movement	excel-in	timing

fú	wéi	bù	zhēng
夫	唯	不	爭
indeed	only	not	contend

gù	wú	yóu
故	無	尤
therefore	without	blame

The highest excellence is like water.
Water benefits the myriad things without striving.
It dwells in places that people reject.
Thus it is close to the Way.
In dwelling, it excels in choosing the right place.
In mind, it excels in depth.
In giving, it excels in benevolence.
In speaking, it excels in truthfulness.
In governance, it excels in order.
In affairs, it excels in capability.
In movement, it excels in timing.
It is precisely because it does not contend.
Therefore it meets no resistance.

Chapter 9

chí	ér	yíng	zhī
持	而	盈	之
hold	and	fill-full	it

bù	rú	qí	yǐ
不	如	其	已
not	like	its	stop

chuāi	ér	ruì	zhī
揣	而	銳	之
measure	and	sharp	it

bù	kě	cháng	bǎo
不	可	長	保
not	can	long	maintain

jīn	yù	mǎn	táng
金	玉	滿	堂
gold	jade	fill	hall

mò	zhī	néng	shǒu
莫	之	能	守
none	it	can	guard

fù	guì	ér	jiāo
富	貴	而	驕
wealth	honor	and	pride

zì	yí	qí	jiù
自	遺	其	咎
self	leave	its	blame

gōng	sùì	shēn	tuì
功	遂	身	退
merit	complete	body	withdraw

tiān	zhī	dào
天	之	道
heaven	of	way

When you hold and fill something to the brim
Better to stop before it overflows
When you sharpen something to a point
The edge cannot be preserved long
When gold and jade fill your halls
No one can protect them
When wealth and status breed arrogance
You bring about your own downfall
When work is done, it is time to retire
This is the Way of Heaven

Chapter 10

zài	yíng	pò	bào	yī
載	營	魄	抱	一
carry	manage	soul	embrace	one

néng	wú	lí	hū
能	無	離	乎
can	not	separate	question

zhuān	qì	zhì	róu
專	氣	致	柔
concentrate	breath	achieve	soft

néng	yīng	ér	hū
能	嬰	兒	乎
can	infant	child	question

dī	chú	xuán	lǎn
滌	除	玄	覽
cleanse	remove	mysterious	view

néng	wú	cǐ	hū
能	無	疵	乎
can	not	flaw	question

ài	mín	zhì	guó
愛	民	治	國
love	people	govern	state

néng	wú	wéi	hū
能	無	為	乎
can	not	act	question

tiān	mén	kāi	hé
天	門	開	闔
heaven	gate	open	close

néng	wéi	cí	hū
能	為	雌	乎
can	act-as	female	question

míng	bái	sì	dá
明	白	四	達
bright	clear	four	reach

néng	wú	yǐ	zhī	hū
能	無	以	知	乎
can	not	by-means-of	know	question

shēng	zhī	xù	zhī
生	之	畜	之
give-birth	them	nourish	them

shēng	ér	bù	yǒu
生	而	不	有
give-birth	yet	not	possess

wéi	ér	bù	shì
為	而	不	恃
act	yet	not	rely-on

zhǎng	ér	bù	zǎi
長	而	不	宰
lead	yet	not	control

shì	wèi	xuán	dé
是	謂	玄	德
this	called	mysterious	virtue

In carrying the spiritual and physical souls while embracing the One
Can you prevent them from separating?
In concentrating your vital breath to achieve softness
Can you be like a newborn child?
In cleansing your inner vision
Can you be without flaw?
In loving the people and governing the state
Can you practice non-action?
As Heaven's gates open and close
Can you play the female part?
When understanding reaches in all directions
Can you be without knowledge?
Give birth to them and nourish them
Give birth but do not possess
Act but do not rely on
Lead but do not dominate
This is called mysterious virtue

Chapter 11

sān	shí	fú	gòng	yī	gū
三	十	輻	共	一	轂
three	ten	spokes	share	one	hub

dāng	qí	wú	yǒu	chē	zhī	yòng
當	其	無	有	車	之	用
precisely	its	nothing	exists	wheel	of	use

shān	zhī	yǐ	wéi	qì
埏	埴	以	為	器
knead	clay	by-means-of	make	vessel

dāng	qí	wú	yǒu	qì	zhī	yòng
當	其	無	有	器	之	用
precisely	its	nothing	exists	vessel	of	use

záo	hù	yǒu	yǐ	wéi	shì
鑿	戶	牖	以	為	室
cut	door	window	by-means-of	make	room

dāng	qí	wú	yǒu	shì	zhī	yòng
當	其	無	有	室	之	用
precisely	its	nothing	exists	room	of	use

gù	yǒu	zhī	yǐ	wéi	lì
故	有	之	以	為	利
therefore	exist	it	by-means-of	make	benefit

wú	zhī	yǐ	wéi	yòng
無	之	以	為	用
nothing	it	by-means-of	make	use

Thirty spokes join together in one hub
It is the empty space that makes the wheel useful.
Clay is molded to make vessels
It is the empty space that makes the vessel useful.
Cut out doors and windows to make a room
It is the empty space that makes the room useful.
Therefore, what exists serves for possession
And what is empty serves for usefulness.

Chapter 12

wū	sè	lìng	rén	mù	máng
五	色	令	人	目	盲
five	colors	cause	person	eye	blind

wū	yīn	lìng	rén	ěr	lóng
五	音	令	人	耳	聾
five	tones	cause	person	ear	deaf

wū	wèi	lìng	rén	kǒu	shuǎng
五	味	令	人	口	爽
five	flavors	cause	person	mouth	numb

chí	chéng	tián	liè	lìng	rén	xīn	fā	kuáng
馳	騁	畋	獵	令	人	心	發	狂
gallop	run	hunt	hunt	cause	person	heart	become	mad

nán	dé	zhī	huò	lìng	rén	xíng	fāng
難	得	之	貨	令	人	行	妨
difficult	obtain	of	goods	cause	person	conduct	harmful

shì	yǐ	shèng	rén
是	以	聖	人
this	by-means-of	sage	person

wéi	fù	bù	wéi	mù
為	腹	不	為	目
act-for	belly	not	act-for	eyes

gù	qù	bǐ	qǔ	cǐ
故	去	彼	取	此
therefore	reject	that	choose	this

The five colors blind people's eyes.
The five tones deafen people's ears.
The five flavors dull people's taste.
Racing and hunting drive people's minds mad.
Rare treasures lead people to harmful behaviors.
Therefore the sage:
Acts for the belly and not for the eyes.
Thus rejects that and chooses this.

Chapter 13

chǒng	rù	ruò	jīng
寵	辱	若	驚
favor	disgrace	like	startle

guì	dà	huàn	ruò	shēn
貴	大	患	若	身
value	great	trouble	like	body

hé	wèi	chǒng	rù	ruò	jīng
何	謂	寵	辱	若	驚
what	mean	favor	disgrace	like	startle

chǒng	wéi	xià	dé	zhī	ruò	jīng
寵	為	下	得	之	若	驚
favor	be	below	obtain	it	like	startle

shī	zhī	ruò	jīng
失	之	若	驚
lose	it	like	startle

shì	wèi	chǒng	rù	ruò	jīng
是	謂	寵	辱	若	驚
this	mean	favor	disgrace	like	startle

hé wèi guì dà huàn ruò shēn
何 謂 貴 大 患 若 身
what mean value great trouble like body

wú suǒyī yǒu dà huàn zhě wéi wú
吾 所以 有 大 患 者 為 吾
I reason have great trouble that-which because I
yǒu shēn
有 身
have body

jí wú wú shēn wú yǒu hé huàn
及 吾 無 身 吾 有 何 患 。
if I not-have body I have what trouble 。

gù guì yǐ shēn wéi tiānxià
。 故 貴 以 身 為 天下
therefore value by-means-of body for all-under-heaven

ruò kě yǐ jì tiānxià yī
若 可 以 寄 天下 矣
if can by-means-of entrust all-under-heaven indeed

ài yǐ shēn wéi tiānxià
愛 以 身 為 天下
love by-means-of body for all-under-heaven

ruò	kě	yǐ	tuō	tiānxià	yī
若	可	以	託	天下	矣
if	can	by-means-of	trust	all-under-heaven	indeed

Honor and disgrace are like sudden shocks.
Value great trouble as you do your body.
What does it mean that honor and disgrace are like sudden shocks?
When favor is received from below, it startles.
When it is lost, it startles.
This is what is meant by honor and disgrace being like sudden shocks.
What does it mean to value great trouble as you do your body?
The reason I have great trouble is because I have a body.
If I had no body, what trouble would I have?
Therefore, one who values the world as he does his body may be entrusted with the world.
One who can be entrusted with the world.
One who loves the world as he does his body may be given the world.
One who can be trusted with the world.

Chapter 14

shì	zhī	bù	jiàn	míng	yuē	yí
視	之	不	見	名	曰	夷
look-at	it	not	see	name	say	subtle

tīng	zhī	bù	wén	míng	yuē	xī
聽	之	不	聞	名	曰	希
listen	it	not	hear	name	say	rare

bó	zhī	bù	dé	míng	yuē	wēi
搏	之	不	得	名	曰	微
grasp	it	not	obtain	name	say	minute

cǐ	sān	zhě	bù	kě	zhì	jié
此	三	者	不	可	致	詰
these	three	ones	not	can	thoroughly	examine

gù	hùn	ér	wéi	yī
故	混	而	為	一
therefore	blend	and	become	one

yī	zhě
一	者
one	that-which

qí	shàng	bù	jiǎo
其	上	不	皦
its	above	not	bright

qí	xià	bù	mèi
其	下	不	昧
its	below	not	dark

shéng	shéng	xī	bù	kě	míng
繩	繩	兮	不	可	名
continuous	continuous	indeed	not	can	name

fù	guī	yú	wú	wù
復	歸	於	無	物
return	return	to	nothing	thing

shì	wèi	wú	zhuàng	zhī	zhuàng
是	謂	無	狀	之	狀
this	called	without	form	of	form

wú	wù	zhī	xiàng
無	物	之	象
without	thing	of	image

shì	wèi	hū	huāng
是	謂	惚	恍
this	called	vague	elusive

yíng	zhī	bù	jiàn	qí	shǒu
迎	之	不	見	其	首
meet	it	not	see	its	head

suí	zhī	bù	jiàn	qí	hòu
隨	之	不	見	其	後
follow	it	not	see	its	behind

zhí	gǔ	zhī	dào
執	古	之	道
hold	ancient	of	way

yǐ	yù	jīn	zhī	yǒu
以	御	今	之	有
by-means-of	master	present	of	existence

néng	zhī	gǔ	shǐ
能	知	古	始
able	know	ancient	beginning

shì	wèi	dào	jì
是	謂	道	紀
this	called	way	thread

Looking at it, it cannot be seen - it is called 'subtle'
Listening for it, it cannot be heard - it is called 'rare'
Grasping for it, it cannot be caught - it is called 'minute'
These three cannot be further explored
Therefore they merge and become one
As for this one
Its above is not bright
Its below is not dark
Continuous and unnameable
Returning again to nothingness
This is called the formless form
The image of nothingness
This is called the vague and elusive
Meeting it, you cannot see its head
Following it, you cannot see its back
Hold to the ancient Way
To master present existence
Being able to know the ancient beginning
This is called the thread of the Way

Chapter 15

gǔ	zhī	shàn	wéi	shì	zhě	wēi	miào
古	之	善	為	士	者	微	妙
ancient	of	good-at	acting-as	master	one-who	subtle	mysterious
xuán	tōng						
玄	通						
profound	penetrating						

shēn	bù	kě	shí
深	不	可	識
deep	not	can	know

fú	wéi	bù	kě	shí
夫	唯	不	可	識
thus	only	not	can	know

gù	qiáng	wéi	zhī	róng
故	強	為	之	容
therefore	force	make	their	appearance

yù	xī	ruò	dōng	shè	chuān
豫	兮	若	冬	涉	川
cautious	!	like	winter	crossing	stream

yóu	xī	ruò	wèi	sì	lín
猶	兮	若	畏	四	鄰
hesitant	!	like	fear	four	neighbors

yǎn xī qí ruò kè
儼 兮 其 若 客
dignified ! it like guest

huàn xī ruò bīng — jiāng shì
渙 兮 若 冰 — 將 釋
dissolving ! like ice about-to melt

dūn xī qí ruò pǔ
敦 兮 其 若 樸
honest ! it like uncarved-wood

kuàng xī qí ruò gǔ
曠 兮 其 若 谷
vast ! it like valley

hùn xī qí ruò zhuó
混 兮 其 若 濁
merged ! it like murky

shú néng zhuó yǐ jìng zhī xú qīng
孰 能 濁 以 靜 之 徐 清
who can murky by-means-of still it gradually clear

shú	néng	ān	yǐ	jiǔ	dòng	zhī	xú
孰	能	安	以	久	動	之	徐
who	can	peaceful	by-means-of	long	movement	it	gradually

shēng
生
live

bǎo	cǐ	dào	zhě	bù	yù	yíng
保	此	道	者	不	欲	盈
preserve	this	way	one-who	not	desire	full

fú	wéi	bù	yíng
夫	唯	不	盈
thus	only	not	full

shì	yǐ	néng	bì	ér	bù	—	chéng
是	以	能	蔽	而	不	—	成
this	by-means-of	can	hide	and	not		complete

The ancient masters of the Way were subtle, mysterious, and profoundly penetrating.

Their depth was beyond comprehension.

Because they were beyond comprehension,

I can only describe their appearance.

Cautious, like crossing a winter stream.

Vigilant, like one wary of neighbors on all sides.

Dignified, like a guest.

Yielding, like ice about to melt.

Simple, like uncarved wood.

Open, like a valley.

Merged, like murky water.

Who can make the murky gradually clear through stillness?

Who can bring life through gradual movement from stillness?

Those who preserve this Way do not desire fullness.

It is because they are not full,

That they can remain hidden and be made anew.

Chapter 16

zhì xū jí
致 虛 極
achieve empty utmost

shǒu jìng dū
守 靜 篤
maintain quiet profound

wàn wù bìng zuò
萬 物 並 作
ten-thousand things together arise

wú yǐ guān qí fù
吾 以 觀 其 復
I by-means-of observe their return

fú wù yúnyún gè fù guī qí gēn
夫 物 芸芸 各 復 歸 其 根
now things abundant each return return-to its root

guī gēn yuē jìng
歸 根 曰 靜
return-to root called quiet

jìng	shì	wèi	fù	mìng
靜	是	謂	復	命
quietude	this	called	return	destiny

fù	mìng	yuē	cháng
復	命	曰	常
return	destiny	called	constant

zhī	cháng	yuē	míng
知	常	曰	明
know	constant	called	bright

bù	zhī	cháng	wàng	zuò	xiōng
不	知	常	妄	作	凶
not	know	constant	reckless	act	misfortune

zhī	cháng	róng
知	常	容
know	constant	capacity

róng	nǎi	gōng
容	乃	公
capacity	leads-to	inclusive

gōng	nǎi	wáng
公	乃	王
inclusive	leads-to	king

wáng	nǎi	tiān
王	乃	天
king	leads-to	heaven

tiān	nǎi	dào
天	乃	道
heaven	leads-to	way

dào	nǎi	jiǔ
道	乃	久
way	leads-to	enduring

mò	shēn	bù	dài
沒	身	不	殆
end	body	not	danger

Achieve utmost emptiness.
Maintain profound quietude.
The ten thousand things arise together.
I thereby observe their return.
Now, all things flourish abundantly, each returning to its root.
Returning to the root is called quietude.
This quietude is called returning to one's destiny.
Returning to destiny is called constancy.
Knowing constancy is called enlightenment.
Not knowing constancy leads to reckless action and misfortune.
Knowing constancy leads to capacity.
Capacity leads to inclusiveness.
Inclusiveness leads to kingliness.
Kingliness leads to heaven.
Heaven leads to the Way.
The Way leads to endurance.
Until the end of one's life, there is no danger.

Chapter 17

tài	shàng	xià	zhī	yǒu	zhī
太	上	下	知	有	之
supreme	highest	below	know	exist	them

qí	cì	qīn	ér	yù	zhī
其	次	親	而	譽	之
their	next	close-to	and	praise	them

qí	cì	wèi	zhī
其	次	畏	之
their	next	fear	them

qí	cì	wū	zhī
其	次	侮	之
their	next	despise	them

xìn	bù	zú	yān	yǒu	bù	xìn	—
信	不	足	焉	有	不	信	
trust	not	sufficient	therein	exist	not	trust	

yóu	xī	qí	guì	yán
猶	兮	其	貴	言
hesitate	ah	their	value	words

gōng	chéng	shì	suí
功	成	事	遂
achievement	complete	affairs	follow

bǎi	xìng	jiē	wèi	wǒ	zì	rán
百	姓	皆	謂	我	自	然
hundred	surnames	all	say	we	self	so

Of the highest rulers, those below merely know they exist.
The next best are loved and praised.
The next are feared.
The next are despised.
When trust is insufficient, there arises distrust.
How careful they are with their words!
When the work is completed and tasks accomplished,
The common people all say, 'We did this naturally.'

Chapter 18

dà dào fèi
大 道 廢
great way abandoned

yǒu rén-yì
有 仁義
exist benevolence-righteousness

huì-zhì chū
慧智 出
wisdom-intelligence emerge

yǒu dà wěi
有 大 偽
exist great falsehood

liù qīn bù hé
六 親 不 和
six relations not harmonious

yǒu xiào cí
有 孝 慈
exist filial-piety compassion

guó	jiā	hūn	luàn
國	家	昏	亂
country	family	confused	chaos

yǒu	zhōng	chén
有	忠	臣
exist	loyal	minister

When the great Way is abandoned,
There arise benevolence and righteousness.
When cleverness emerges,
There arises great pretense.
When the six family relationships are not in harmony,
There arise filial piety and compassion.
When the country falls into chaos,
There arise loyal ministers.

Chapter 19

jué	shèng	qì	zhì
絕	聖	棄	智
cut-off	sagacity	abandon	wisdom

mín	lì	bǎi	bèi
民	利	百	倍
people	benefit	hundred	times

jué	rén	qì	yì
絕	仁	棄	義
cut-off	benevolence	abandon	righteousness

mín	fù	xiào	cí
民	復	孝	慈
people	return	filial	compassion

jué	qiǎo	qì	lì
絕	巧	棄	利
cut-off	cleverness	abandon	profit

dào	zéi	wú	yǒu
盜	賊	無	有
thief	bandit	not	exist

cǐ	sān	zhě	yǐ	wéi	wén	bù	zú
此	三	者	以	為	文	不	足
these	three	ones	by-means-of	make	culture	not	enough

gù	lǐng	yǒu	suǒ	shǔ
故	令	有	所	屬
therefore	cause	have	that-which	belong

jiàn	sù
見	素
see	plain

bào	pǔ
抱	樸
embrace	simplicity

shǎo	sī
少	私
decrease	private

guá	yù
寡	欲
few	desire

Abandon sagacity, discard knowledge
And the people will benefit a hundredfold
Abandon benevolence, discard righteousness
And the people will return to filial piety and compassion
Abandon cleverness, discard profit
And thieves and robbers will disappear
These three things are ornamental and thus inadequate
Therefore ensure there are these to embrace
See the plain
Embrace simplicity
Lessen self-interest
Reduce desires

Chapter 20

jué	xué	wú	yōu
絕	學	無	憂
cut-off	learning	without	worry

wéi	zhī	yǔ	ā
唯	之	與	阿
yes	of	and	yeah

xiāng	qù	jǐ	hé
相	去	幾	何
mutually	separate	how-much	what

měi	zhī	yǔ	è
美	之	與	惡
good	of	and	evil

xiāng	qù	ruò	hé
相	去	若	何
mutually	separate	like	what

rén	zhī	suǒ	wèi	bù	kě	bù	wèi
人	之	所	畏	不	可	不	畏
people	of	that-which	fear	not	can	not	fear

huáng	xī	qí	wèi	yāng	zāi
荒	兮	其	未	央	哉
wild	ah	it	not-yet	end	indeed

zhòng	rén	xī	xī
眾	人	熙	熙
many	people	bright	bright

rú	xiǎng	tài	láo
如	享	太	牢
like	enjoy	great	sacrifice

rú	chūn	dēng	tái
如	春	登	臺
like	spring	climb	terrace

wǒ	dú	bó	xī
我	獨	泊	兮
I	alone	still	ah

qí	wèi	zhào
其	未	兆
it	not-yet	show-sign

rú	yīng	ér	zhī	wèi	hái
如	嬰	兒	之	未	孩
like	infant	child	of	not-yet	smile

lěi	lěi	xī	ruò	wú	suǒ	guī
儼	儼	兮	若	無	所	歸
tired	tired	ah	like	no	place	return

zhòng	rén	jiē	yǒu	yú
眾	人	皆	有	餘
many	people	all	have	excess

wǒ	dú	ruò	yí	
—	我	獨	若	遺
	I	alone	like	lost

wǒ	yú	rén	zhī	xīn	yě	zāi
我	愚	人	之	心	也	哉
I	foolish	person	of	heart	indeed	indeed

dùn	dùn	xī
沌	沌	兮
chaos	chaos	ah

sú	rén	zhāo	zhāo
俗	人	昭	昭
common	people	bright	bright

wǒ	dú	ruò	hūn
我	獨	若	昏
I	alone	like	dark

sú	rén	chá	chá
俗	人	察	察
common	people	examine	examine

wǒ	dú	mèn	mèn
我	獨	悶	悶
I	alone	depressed	depressed

dàn	xī	qí	ruò	hǎi
澹	兮	其	若	海
calm	ah	it	like	sea

piāo	xī	ruò	wú	suǒ	zhǐ
漂	兮	若	無	所	止
drift	ah	like	no	place	stop

zhòng	rén	jiē	yǒu	yǐ
眾	人	皆	有	以
many	people	all	have	by-means-of

wó	dú	wán	sì	bī	
——	我	獨	頑	似	鄙
	I	alone	stubborn	seem	vulgar

wǒ	dú	yì	yú	rén
我	獨	異	於	人
I	alone	different	from	people

ér	guì	shí	mǔ
而	貴	食	母
and	value	feed	mother

Abandon learning and there will be no sorrow.
Between 'yes' and 'yeah', how much difference is there?
How far apart are they?
Between good and evil, how much difference is there?
How far apart are they?
What others fear, one must also fear.
How boundless it seems!
The masses are joyous and merry.
As if enjoying a great feast.
As if ascending a terrace in spring.
I alone am still and unmoving.
Like an infant who has not yet smiled.
Like a newborn who has not yet smiled.
Weary, as though having no home to return to.
The masses all have more than enough.
I alone appear to be lacking.
Mine is indeed the mind of a fool.
So muddled!
Common people are bright.
I alone am dim.
Common people are discriminating.
I alone am muddled.
Boundless like the sea.
Drifting as if with nowhere to rest.
The masses all have their purpose.
I alone am stubborn and uncouth.
I alone differ from others.
And value drawing sustenance from the Mother.

Chapter 21

kòng	dé	zhī	róng	wéi	dào	shì	cóng
孔	德	之	容	唯	道	是	從
great	virtue	of	appearance	only	way	is	follow

dào	zhī	wéi	wù	wéi	huāng	wéi	hū
道	之	為	物	唯	恍	唯	惚
way	of	as	thing	only	vague	only	indistinct

hū	xī	huāng	xī	qí	zhōng	yǒu	xiàng
惚	兮	恍	兮	其	中	有	象
indistinct	ah	vague	ah	its	within	have	image

huāng	xī	hū	xī	qí	zhōng	yǒu	wù
恍	兮	惚	兮	其	中	有	物
vague	ah	indistinct	ah	its	within	have	thing

yào	xī	míng	xī	qí	zhōng	yǒu	jīng
窈	兮	冥	兮	其	中	有	精
deep	ah	dark	ah	its	within	have	essence

qí	jīng	shèn	zhēn
其	精	甚	真
its	essence	very	real

qí	zhōng	yǒu	xìn
其	中	有	信
its	within	have	truth

zì	jīn	jí	gǔ
自	今	及	古
from	present	reach	ancient

qí	míng	bù	qù
其	名	不	去
its	name	not	depart

yǐ	yuè	zhòng	fù
以	閱	眾	甫
by-means-of	examine	many	beginning

wú	hé	yǐ	zhī	zhòng	fù	zhī	rán	zāi
吾	何	以	知	眾	甫	之	然	哉
I	how	by-means-of	know	many	beginning	of	thus	indeed

yǐ	cǐ
以	此
by-means-of	this

The manifestation of great virtue follows only the Dao.
The Dao as a thing is but vague and elusive.
Indistinct and vague, yet within it there are images.
Vague and indistinct, yet within it there are things.
Deep and dark, yet within it there is essence.
This essence is very real.
Within it there is truth.
From ancient times until now,
Its name has never departed.
Through it we observe all beginnings.
How do I know the nature of all beginnings?
Through this.

Chapter 22

qū	zé	quán
曲	則	全
bent	then	complete

wǎng	zé	zhí
枉	則	直
crooked	then	straight

wǎ	zé	yíng
窪	則	盈
hollow	then	full

bì	zé	xīn
敝	則	新
worn	then	new

shǎo	zé	dé
少	則	得
little	then	gain

duō	zé	huò
多	則	惑
much	then	confused

shì	yǐ	shèng	rén
是	以	聖	人
this	by-means-of	sage	person

bào	yī	yǐ	wéi	tiān-xià	shì
抱	一	以	為	天下	式
embrace	one	by-means-of	become	under-heaven	model

bù	zì	jiàn	gù	míng
不	自	見	故	明
not	self	show	therefore	bright

bù	zì	shì	gù	zhāng
不	自	是	故	彰
not	self	right	therefore	distinct

bù	zì	fā	gù	yǒu	gōng
不	自	伐	故	有	功
not	self	boast	therefore	have	merit

bù	zì	jīn	gù	cháng
不	自	矜	故	長
not	self	pride	therefore	long

fú	wéi	bù	zhēng
夫	唯	不	爭
indeed	only	not	contend

gù	tiān-xià	mò	néng	yǔ	zhī	zhēng
故	天下	莫	能	與	之	爭
therefore	under-heaven	none	can	with	them	contend

gǔ	zhī	suǒ	wèi
古	之	所	謂
ancient	of	that-which	called

qū	zé	quán	zhě
曲	則	全	者
bent	then	complete	one-who

qǐ	xū	yán	zāi
豈	虛	言	哉
how	empty	words	indeed

chéng	quán	ér	guī	zhī
誠	全	而	歸	之
truly	complete	and	return	to-it

What is bent becomes whole.
What is crooked becomes straight.
What is empty becomes full.
What is worn becomes new.
With little, one gains.
With much, one becomes confused.
Therefore the sage
Embraces the One as the model for all under heaven
Not displaying self, thus bright
Not asserting self, thus distinct
Not boasting, thus meritorious
Not being prideful, thus lasting
It is because one does not contend
Therefore none under heaven can contend with them
The ancient saying
'The bent becomes whole'
How could these be empty words?
Truly, become whole and return to it.

Chapter 23

xī yán zì rán
希 言 自 然
sparse words self so

• gù piāo fēng bù zhōng zhāo
故 飄 風 不 終 朝
therefore whirling wind not end morning

zhòu yǔ bù zhōng rì
驟 雨 不 終 日
sudden rain not end day

shú wéi cǐ zhě tiān dì
孰 為 此 者 天 地
who make these one-who heaven earth

tiān dì shàng bù néng jiǔ
天 地 尚 不 能 久
heaven earth even not can long

ér kuàng yú rén hū
而 況 於 人 乎 •
and moreover to human question

• 故 從 事 於 道 者
therefore follow affairs to way one-who

道 者 同 於 道
way one-who align with way

德 者 同 於 德
virtue one-who align with virtue

失 者 同 於 失
loss one-who align with loss

同 於 道 者
align with way one-who

道 亦 樂 得 之
way also joy obtain them

同 於 德 者
align with virtue one-who

dé	yì	lè	dé	zhī
德	亦	樂	得	之
virtue	also	joy	obtain	them

tóng	yú	shī	zhě
同	於	失	者
align	with	loss	one-who

shī	yì	lè	dé	zhī
失	亦	樂	得	之
loss	also	joy	obtain	them

xìn	bù	zú	yān	yǒu	bù	xìn	—
信	不	足	焉	有	不	信	
trust	not	sufficient	therein	exist	not	trust	

Sparse words are natural.
Therefore, a whirlwind does not last all morning,
A sudden rain does not last all day.
Who creates these? Heaven and Earth.
Even Heaven and Earth cannot make them last long,
How much less can humans?
Therefore, those who follow the Way,
Those of the Way align with the Way.
Those of virtue align with virtue.
Those of loss align with loss.
Those who align with the Way,
The Way joyfully accepts them.
Those who align with virtue,
Virtue joyfully accepts them.
Those who align with loss,
Loss joyfully accepts them.
When trust is insufficient, there exists distrust.

Chapter 24

qǐ	zhě	bù	lì
企	者	不	立
tiptoe	one-who	not	stand

kuà	zhě	bù	xíng
跨	者	不	行
stride	one-who	not	walk

zì	jiàn	zhě	bù	míng
自	見	者	不	明
self	see	one-who	not	bright

zì	shì	zhě	bù	zhāng
自	是	者	不	彰
self	right	one-who	not	manifest

zì	fà	zhě	wú	gōng
自	伐	者	無	功
self	boast	one-who	without	merit

zì	jīn	zhě	bù	cháng
自	矜	者	不	長
self	pride	one-who	not	endure

qí zài dào yě
其 在 道 也
it in way indeed

yuē yú shí zhuì xíng
曰 餘 食 贅 行
called excess food superfluous action

wù huò wù zhī
物 或 惡 之
things perhaps despise them

gù yǒu dào zhě bù chǔ
故 有 道 者 不 處
therefore have way one-who not dwell

One who stands on tiptoe cannot stand firm.
One who strides cannot walk far.
One who displays himself does not shine.
One who asserts himself is not distinguished.
One who boasts of himself achieves no merit.
One who is proud of himself does not endure.
In relation to the Way, these are called:
Excess food and unnecessary actions.
Such things are despised by all creatures.
Therefore, one who follows the Way does not dwell in them.

Chapter 25

yǒu	wù	hùn	chéng
有	物	混	成
exists	thing	chaos	complete

xiān	tiān	dì	shēng
先	天	地	生
before	heaven	earth	born

jì	xī	liáo	xī
寂	兮	寥	兮
silent	!	void	!

dú	lì	bù	gǎi
獨	立	不	改
alone	stand	not	change

zhōu	xíng	ér	bù	dài
周	行	而	不	殆
cycle	move	and	not	danger

kě	yǐ	wéi	tiān	xià	mǔ
可	以	為	天	下	母
can	by-means-of	be	heaven	below	mother

wú bù zhī qí míng
吾 不 知 其 名
I not know its name

zì zhī yuē dào
字 之 曰 道
designate it say way

qiáng wéi zhī míng yuē dà
強 為 之 名 曰 大
force make it name say great

dà yuē shì
大 曰 逝
great say passing

shì yuē yuǎn
逝 曰 遠
passing say far

yuǎn yuē fǎn
遠 曰 反
far say return

—— dào dà
—— 道 大
way great

tiān dà
heaven great

dì dà
earth great

wáng yì dà
ruler also great

yù zhōng yǒu sì dà
realm within exist four great

ér wáng jū qí yī yān
and ruler occupy its one thereof

rén fǎ dì
human model earth

dì fǎ tiān
earth model heaven

tiān fǎ dào
天 法 道
heaven model way

dào fǎ zì rán
道 法 自 然
way model self so

There was something formed in chaos
Born before Heaven and Earth
Silent and void
Standing alone and unchanging
Circulating endlessly without danger
It can be regarded as the mother of all under heaven
I do not know its name
Designating it, I call it Dao
Forced to give it a name, I call it Great
Great means passing beyond
Passing beyond means far-reaching
Far-reaching means returning
Therefore, the Dao is great
Heaven is great
Earth is great
The ruler is also great
Within the realm there are four greats
And the ruler occupies one of them
Humans follow Earth
Earth follows Heaven
Heaven follows the Dao
The Dao follows what is natural

Chapter 26

zhòng	wéi	qīng	gēn
重	為	輕	根
heavy	becomes	light	root

jìng	wéi	zào	jūn
靜	為	躁	君
still	becomes	restless	ruler

shì	yǐ	jūnzǐ	zhōng	rì
是	以	君子	終	日
this	by-means-of	noble-person	throughout	day

xíng	bù	lí	qí	zì
行	不	離	其	輜
travel	not	leave	their	wagon

zhòng	suī	yǒu	róng	guān	yàn
重	雖	有	榮	觀	燕
heavy	although	have	glory	view	feast

chǔ	chāo	rán
處	超	然
dwell	transcend	thus

nài	hé	wàn	shèng	zhī	zhǔ
奈	何	萬	乘	之	主
how	what	ten-thousand	chariots	of	lord

ér	yǐ	shēn	qīng	tiān	xià
而	以	身	輕	天	下
yet	by-means-of	body	light	heaven	below

qīng	zé	shī	běn
輕	則	失	本
light	then	lose	root

zào	zé	shī	jūn
躁	則	失	君
restless	then	lose	ruler

Heaviness is the root of lightness.
Stillness is the master of restlessness.
Therefore the noble person throughout the day
Travels without leaving their supply wagons.
Though there are magnificent sights to see,
They remain serenely unattached.
How can the lord of ten thousand chariots
Treat their body lightly in governing the world?
In lightness, the root is lost.
In restlessness, mastery is lost.

Chapter 27

shàn	xíng	wú	zhéjì
善	行	無	轍迹
good	walk	without	wheel-tracks

shàn	yán	wú	xiázhé
善	言	無	瑕謫
good	speak	without	flaw-blame

shàn	shù	bù	yòng	chóucè
善	數	不	用	籌策
good	count	not	use	counting-tools

shàn	bì	wú	guānjiàn	ér	bù	kě	kāi
善	閉	無	關鍵	而	不	可	開
good	close	without	bolt-bar	yet	not	can	open

shàn	jié	wú	móyuē	ér	bù	kě	jiě
善	結	無	繆約	而	不	可	解
good	tie	without	rope-bind	yet	not	can	untie

shì	yǐ	shèng	rén
是	以	聖	人
this	by-means-of	sage	person

cháng	shàn	jiù	rén
常	善	救	人
always	good-at	save	people

gù	wú	qì	rén
故	無	棄	人
therefore	without	abandon	person

cháng	shàn	jiù	wù
常	善	救	物
always	good-at	save	things

gù	wú	qì	wù
故	無	棄	物
therefore	without	abandon	things

shì	wèi	xí	míng
是	謂	襲	明
this	called	inherit	brightness

gù	shàn	rén	zhě	bù	shàn	rén	zhī	shī
故	善	人	者	不	善	人	之	師
therefore	good	person	one-who	not	good	person	of	teacher

bù	shàn	rén	zhě	shàn	rén	zhī	zī
不	善	人	者	善	人	之	資
not	good	person	one-who	good	person	of	resource

bù	guì	qí	shī
不	貴	其	師
not	value	one's	teacher

bù	ài	qí	zī
不	愛	其	資
not	love	one's	resource

suī	zhì	dà	mí
雖	智	大	迷
although	wisdom	great	confused

shì	wéi	yào	miào
是	謂	要	妙
this	called	essential	mystery

Good walking leaves no tracks.
Good speech has no flaws.
Good counting needs no tools.
Good closing needs no bolt or lock, yet cannot be opened.
Good tying uses no rope, yet cannot be untied.
Therefore the sage
Always is good at saving people
Therefore abandons no one
Always is good at saving things
Therefore abandons nothing.
This is called following the light.
Therefore, the good person is the teacher of the not-good person.
The not-good person is the resource of the good person.
Not valuing one's teacher
Not loving one's resource
Though clever, greatly confused
This is called the essential mystery.

Chapter 28

zhī	qí	xióng	shǒu	qí	cí
知	其	雄	守	其	雌
know	its	masculine	maintain	its	feminine

wéi	tiān	xià	xī
為	天	下	谿
become	heaven	below	stream

wéi	tiān	xià	xī
為	天	下	谿
become	heaven	below	stream

cháng	dé	bù	lí
常	德	不	離
constant	virtue	not	depart

fù	guī	yú	yīng	ér
復	歸	於	嬰	兒
return	return-to	to	infant	child

zhī	qí	bái	shǒu	qí	hēi
知	其	白	守	其	黑
know	its	white	maintain	its	black

wéi	tiān	xià	shì
為	天	下	式
become	heaven	below	model

wéi	tiān	xià	shì
為	天	下	式
become	heaven	below	model

cháng	dé	bù	tè
常	德	不	忒
constant	virtue	not	err

fù	guī	yú	wú	jí
復	歸	於	無	極
return	return-to	to	without	limit

zhī	qí	róng	shǒu	qí	rǔ
知	其	榮	守	其	辱
know	its	glory	maintain	its	humility

wéi	tiān	xià	gǔ
為	天	下	谷
become	heaven	below	valley

wéi	tiān	xià	gǔ
為	天	下	谷
become	heaven	below	valley

cháng	dé	nǎi	zú
常	德	乃	足
constant	virtue	then	sufficient

fù	guī	yú	pǔ
復	歸	於	樸
return	return-to	to	simplicity

pǔ	sàn	zé	wéi	qì
樸	散	則	為	器
simplicity	scatter	then	become	vessel

shèng	rén	yòng	zhī	zé	wéi	guān	zhǎng
聖	人	用	之	則	為	官	長
sage	person	use	it	then	become	official	leader

gù	dà	zhì	bù	gē
故	大	制	不	割
therefore	great	system	not	cut

Know the masculine, but keep to the feminine
Become the stream of the world
Become the stream of the world
The constant virtue never departs
Return again to the infant state
Know the white, but keep to the black
Become the model for the world
Become the model for the world
The constant virtue never errs
Return again to the limitless
Know the glory, but keep to humility
Become the valley of the world
Become the valley of the world
The constant virtue is then sufficient
Return again to simplicity
When simplicity is divided, it becomes vessels
When the sage uses it, they become leaders
Therefore the great system does not cut apart

Chapter 29

jiāng yù qǔ tiān-xià ér wéi zhī
將 欲 取 天下 而 為 之
about-to desire take all-under-heaven and do it

wú jiàn qí bù dé yǐ
吾 見 其 不 得 已
I see its not obtain already

fú tiān-xià shén-qì
夫 天下 神器
indeed all-under-heaven sacred-vessel

bù kě wéi yě
不 可 為 也
not can do indeed

wéi zhě bài zhī
為 者 敗 之
do one-who ruin it

zhí zhě shī zhī
執 者 失 之
grasp one-who lose it

gù	wù
故	物
therefore	things

huò	xíng	huò	suí
或	行	或	隨
some	walk	some	follow

huò	xū	huò	chuī
或	歔	或	吹
some	inhale	some	blow

huò	qiáng	huò	léi
或	強	或	羸
some	strong	some	weak

huò	cuò	huò	huī
或	挫	或	隳
some	break	some	collapse

shì	yǐ	shèng-rén
是	以	聖人
this	by-means-of	sage-person

qù	shèn
去	甚
remove	excessive

qù	shē
去	奢
remove	extravagant

qù	tài
去	泰
remove	extreme

When one desires to take control of the world and act upon it,
I observe that they will certainly fail.
For the world is a sacred vessel.
It cannot be acted upon.
Those who act upon it will ruin it.
Those who grasp it will lose it.
Therefore in all things:
Some lead, some follow,
Some breathe gently, some breathe strongly,
Some are strong, some are weak,
Some break down, some fall apart.
Therefore the sage:
Eliminates excess,
Eliminates extravagance,
Eliminates extremes.

Chapter 30

yǐ	dào	zuǒ	rén	zhǔ	zhě
以	道	佐	人	主	者
by-means-of	way	assist	person	ruler	one-who

bù	yǐ	bīng	qiáng	tiān	xià
不	以	兵	強	天	下
not	by-means-of	weapons	force	heaven	below

qí	shì	hǎo	huán
其	事	好	還
its	affairs	tend-to	return

shī	zhī	suǒ	chǔ	jīngjí	shēng
師	之	所	處	荊棘	生
army	of	place	dwell	thorns-brambles	grow

yān	dà	jūn	zhī	hòu	bì	yǒu	xiōng	nián
焉	大	軍	之	後	必	有	凶	年
thereupon	great	army	of	after	surely	have	disaster	year

shàn	zhě	guǒ	ér	yǐ
善	者	果	而	已
good	one-who	result	and	stop

bù	gǎn	yǐ	qǔ	qiáng
不	敢	以	取	強
not	dare	by-means-of	take	force

guǒ	ér	wù	jīn
果	而	勿	矜
result	and	do-not	boast

guǒ	ér	wù	fá
果	而	勿	伐
result	and	do-not	attack

guǒ	ér	wù	jiāo
果	而	勿	驕
result	and	do-not	arrogant

guǒ	ér	bù	dé	yǐ
果	而	不	得	已
result	and	not	obtain	already

guǒ	ér	wù	qiáng
果	而	勿	強
result	and	do-not	force

wù	zhuàng	zé	lǎo
物	壯	則	老
things	strong	then	old

shì	wèi	bù	dào
是	謂	不	道
this	called	not	way

bù	dào	zǎo	yǐ
不	道	早	已
not	way	early	end

One who assists a ruler according to the Dao
Does not use military force to dominate the world
Such affairs tend to return upon themselves
Where armies camp, thorns and brambles grow
After great armies, years of famine surely follow
The good achieve their purpose and stop
Not daring to take by force
Achieve results but do not boast
Achieve results but do not brag
Achieve results but do not be arrogant
Achieve results because there is no choice
Achieve results but do not force
Things at their peak must decline
This is called not following the Dao
Not following the Dao ends early

Chapter 31

fū jiā bīng zhě bùxiáng zhī qì
夫 佳 兵 者 不祥 之 器
now fine weapon one-who ill-omen of instrument

wù huò wù zhī
物 或 惡 之
things perhaps detest it

gù yǒu dào zhě bù chù
故 有 道 者 不 處
therefore have way one-who not dwell

jūnzi jū zé guì zuǒ
君 子 居 則 貴 左
noble-one dwell then value left

yòng bīng zé guì yòu
用 兵 則 貴 右
use weapon then value right

bīng zhě bùxiáng zhī qì
兵 者 不祥 之 器
weapon one-who ill-omen of instrument

fēi jūnzǐ zhī qì
非 君子 之 器
not noble-one of instrument

bùdéyǐ ér yòng zhī
不得已 而 用 之
no-alternative and use them

tiándàn wéi shàng
恬淡 為 上
calm-peaceful make supreme

—— wù měi yě
—— 勿 美 也
do-not beautify indeed

ér měi zhī zhě shì lè shā rén
而 美 之 者 是 樂 殺 人
yet beautify them one-who is delight kill person

fū lè shā rén zhě
夫 樂 殺 人 者
now delight kill person one-who

— bù kěyǐ dézhì yú tiānxià yī
not can achieve-will in under-heaven indeed

gù jí shì shàng zuǒ
故 吉 事 尚 左
therefore auspicious matter favor left

xiōng shì shàng yòu
凶 事 尚 右
inauspicious matter favor right

shìyǐ piān jiāngjūn jū zuǒ
是 以 偏 將 軍 居 左
thus lieutenant general stands left

shàng jiāngjūn jū yòu
上 將 軍 居 右
supreme general stands right

yán yǐ sānglǐ chù zhī
言 以 喪 禮 處 之
speak by-means-of funeral-rites place them

shā rén — zhòng
殺 人 眾
kill person many

yǐ āi bēi qì zhī
以 哀 悲 泣 之
by-means-of sorrow grief weep them

zhàn shèng yǐ sānglǐ chù zhī
戰 勝 以 喪禮 處 之
battle victory by-means-of funeral-rites treat it

Now, fine weapons are instruments of ill omen.
Some things are detested by all.
Therefore, those who possess the Way do not dwell with them.
The noble one values the left when at home.
In war, one values the right.
Weapons are instruments of ill omen.
They are not the tools of a noble one.
Only when forced will one use them.
Calmness and tranquility are considered best.
Do not glorify them.
Those who glorify them delight in killing people.
Now, one who delights in killing people
Cannot achieve their will in the world.
Therefore in auspicious matters, favor the left.
In inauspicious matters, favor the right.
Thus the lieutenant general stands on the left.
The supreme general stands on the right.
This means they are placed according to funeral rites.
When many people are killed
One should weep for them with sorrow.
Victory in battle should be treated as a funeral.

Chapter 32

dào	cháng	wú	míng
道	常	無	名
way	constant	without	name

pǔ	suī	xiǎo
樸	雖	小
uncarved-block	although	small

tiān	xià	mò	néng	chén	—
天	下	莫	能	臣	
heaven	below	none	can	subordinate	

hóu	wáng	ruò	néng	shǒu	zhī
侯	王	若	能	守	之
lords	kings	if	can	preserve	it

wàn	wù	jiāng	zì	bīn
萬	物	將	自	賓
ten-thousand	things	will	self	submit

tiān	dì	xiāng	hé
天	地	相	合
heaven	earth	mutually	join

yǐ	jiàng	gān	lù
以	降	甘	露
by-means-of	descend	sweet	dew

mín	mò	zhī	lìng
民	莫	之	令
people	none	it	command

ér	zì	jūn
而	自	均
yet	self	equal

yān	shǐ	zhì	yǒu	míng
焉	始	制	有	名
thereupon	begin	system	have	name

míng	yì	jì	yǒu
名	亦	既	有
name	also	already	have

fū	yì	jiāng	zhī	zhǐ
夫	亦	將	知	止
then	also	will	know	stop

zhī	zhǐ	suǒ	yǐ	bù	dài
知	止	所	以	不	殆
know	stop	that-which	by-means-of	not	danger

pì	dào	zhī	zài	tiān	xià
譬	道	之	在	天	下
compare	way	of	exist	heaven	below

yóu	chuān	gǔ	zhī	yǔ	jiāng	hǎi
猶	川	谷	之	與	江	海
like	streams	valleys	of	and	rivers	seas

The Dao is eternally nameless.
Though the uncarved block is small,
None under heaven can subordinate it.
If lords and kings could preserve it,
The ten thousand things would submit naturally.
Heaven and Earth combine,
To send down sweet dew.
Without command, people naturally become equal.
Yet naturally achieve harmony.
When order begins, names arise.
Once names exist,
One must know when to stop.
Knowing when to stop prevents danger.
The Dao in the world,
Is like streams and valleys flowing into rivers and seas.

Chapter 33

zhī	rén	zhě	zhì
知	人	者	智
know	others	one-who	wise

zì	zhī	zhě	míng
自	知	者	明
self	know	one-who	bright

shèng	rén	zhě	yǒu	lì
勝	人	者	有	力
overcome	others	one-who	have	force

zì	shèng	zhě	qiáng
自	勝	者	強
self	overcome	one-who	strong

zhī	zú	zhě	fù
知	足	者	富
know	enough	one-who	wealthy

qiáng	xíng	zhě	yǒu	zhì
強	行	者	有	志
forceful	act	one-who	have	will

bù	shī	qí	suǒ	zhě	jiǔ
不	失	其	所	者	久
not	lose	their	place	one-who	endure

sǐ	ér	bù	wáng	zhě	shòu
死	而	不	亡	者	壽
die	yet	not	perish	one-who	long-lived

One who knows others is wise.
One who knows oneself has clarity.
One who overcomes others has force.
One who overcomes oneself is strong.
One who knows contentment is wealthy.
One who acts with determination has will.
One who loses not their position endures.
One who dies but does not perish has longevity.

Chapter 34

dà dào fàn xī
大 道 汜 兮
great way overflow indeed

qí kě zuǒ yòu
其 可 左 右
it can left right

wàn wù shì zhī yǐ shēng
萬 物 恃 之 以 生
ten-thousand things depend-on it by-means-of live

ér bù cí
而 不 辭
yet not refuse

gōng chéng suì
功 成 遂
achievement complete then

ér bù míng yǒu
而 不 名 有
yet not name possess

yī	yǎng	wàn	wù
衣	養	萬	物
clothe	nourish	ten-thousand	things

ér	bù	wéi	zhǔ
而	不	為	主
yet	not	act-as	master

gù	cháng	wú	yù
故	常	無	欲
therefore	constant	without	desire

kě	míng	yú	xiǎo
可	名	於	小
can	name	among	small

wàn	wù	guī	yān
萬	物	歸	焉
ten-thousand	things	return	thereto

ér	bù	wéi	zhǔ
而	不	為	主
yet	not	act-as	master

kě	míng	yú	dà
可	名	於	大
can	name	among	great

shì yǐ shèng rén zhī néng chéng dà
是以 聖人之能成大
thus sage of can achieve great

yǐ qí bù wéi dà
以其不為大
because they not act-as great

gù néng chéng — dà
故能成 — 大
therefore can achieve great

The great Dao flows everywhere.
It can go left and right.
All things rely on it for life.
Yet it does not refuse them.
When work is accomplished, it succeeds.
Yet it does not claim possession.
It clothes and nourishes all things.
Yet does not act as their master.
Therefore it constantly lacks desires.
It can be named among the small.
All things return to it.
Yet it does not act as their master.
It can be named among the great.
Thus the sage can achieve greatness.
Because they do not make themselves great.
Therefore they can achieve greatness.

Chapter 35

zhí dà xiàng
執 大 象
grasp great image

tiān xià wǎng
天 下 往
heaven below go-toward

wǎng ér bù hài
往 而 不 害
go-toward and not harm

ān píng tài
安 平 太
peaceful level great

yuè yǔ ěr guò kè zhǐ
樂 與 餌 過 客 止
music and food pass guest stop

dào zhī chū yán dàn hē
道 之 出 言 淡 呵
way of emerge speak bland ah

qí	wú	wèi
其	無	味
its	without	flavor

shǐ	zhī	bù	zú	jiàn
視	之	不	足	見
look	it	not	sufficient	see

tīng	zhī	bù	zú	wén
聽	之	不	足	聞
listen	it	not	sufficient	hear

yòng	zhī	bù	zú	jì
用	之	不	足	既
use	it	not	sufficient	exhaust

Hold fast to the Great Image
All under heaven will come
They come and are not harmed
Finding peace, equality, and greatness
Music and food cause passing travelers to stop
When the Dao is expressed in words, how bland it seems
How flavorless it is
Look at it, it cannot be seen enough
Listen to it, it cannot be heard enough
Use it, it cannot be exhausted

Chapter 36

jiāng	yù	shè	zhī
將	欲	歛	之
about-to	wish	contract	it

bì	gù	zhāng	zhī
必	固	張	之
must	indeed	expand	it

jiāng	yù	ruò	zhī
將	欲	弱	之
about-to	wish	weaken	it

bì	gù	qiáng	zhī
必	固	強	之
must	indeed	strengthen	it

jiāng	yù	fèi	zhī
將	欲	廢	之
about-to	wish	abandon	it

bì	gù	xīng	zhī
必	固	興	之
must	indeed	flourish	it

jiāng	yù	duó	zhī
將	欲	奪	之
about-to	wish	take	it

bì	gù	yǔ	zhī
必	固	與	之
must	indeed	give	it

shì	wèi	wēi	míng
是	謂	微	明
this	called	subtle	bright

róu	ruò	shèng	gāng	qiáng
柔	弱	勝	剛	強
soft	weak	overcome	hard	strong

yú	bù	kě	tuō	yú	yuān
魚	不	可	脫	於	淵
fish	not	can	escape	from	deep-waters

guó	zhī	lì	qì
國	之	利	器
state	of	sharp	tools

bù	kě	yǐ	shì	rén
不	可	以	示	人
not	can	by-means-of	show	people

If you wish to shrink something
You must first allow it to expand
If you wish to weaken something
You must first allow it to strengthen
If you wish to abandon something
You must first allow it to flourish
If you wish to take something
You must first allow it to be given
This is called subtle illumination
The soft and weak overcome the hard and strong
Fish cannot leave their deep waters
The state's sharp weapons
Should not be displayed to others

Chapter 37

dào	cháng	wú	wéi
道	常	無	為
way	constant	without	doing

ér	wú	bù	wéi
而	無	不	為
yet	without	not	doing

hóu	wáng	ruò	néng	shǒu	zhī
侯	王	若	能	守	之
marquis	king	if	can	maintain	it

wàn	wù	jiāng	zì	huà
萬	物	將	自	化
ten-thousand	things	will	self	transform

huà	ér	yù	zuò
化	而	欲	作
transform	and	desire	arise

wú	jiāng	zhèn	zhī	yǐ	wú	míng	zhī
吾	將	鎮	之	以	無	名	之
I	will	stabilize	it	by-means-of	without	name	of

pǔ
樸
simplicity

wú	míng	zhī	pǔ
無	名	之	樸
without	name	of	simplicity

fú	yì	jiāng	wú	yù
夫	亦	將	無	欲
indeed	also	will	without	desire

bù	yù	yǐ	jìng
不	欲	以	靜
not	desire	by-means-of	stillness

tiān	xià	jiāng	zì	dìng
天	下	將	自	定
heaven	below	will	self	settle

The Dao constantly practices non-action.
Yet there is nothing it does not do.
If lords and kings could maintain this,
All things would transform naturally.
When transformed, if desire should arise,
I would stabilize them through the nameless uncarved block.
The nameless uncarved block
Indeed, shall also be without desire.
Through desirelessness comes stillness,
And the world will naturally settle into order.

Chapter 38

shàng dé bù dé shì yǐ yǒu dé
上 德 不 德 是 以 有 德
highest virtue not virtuous this therefore have virtue

xià dé bù shī dé shì yǐ wú dé
下 德 不 失 德 是 以 無 德
lower virtue not lose virtue this therefore without virtue

shàng dé wú wéi ér wú yǐ wéi
上 德 無 為 而 無 以 為
highest virtue without action and without by-means-of action

xià dé wéi zhī ér yǒu yǐ wéi
下 德 為 之 而 有 以 為
lower virtue acts it and have by-means-of action

shàng rén wéi zhī ér wú yǐ wéi
上 仁 為 之 而 無 以 為
highest benevolence acts it and without by-means-of action

shàng yì wéi zhī ér yǒu yǐ wéi
上 義 為 之 而 有 以 為
highest righteousness acts it and have by-means-of action

shàng lǐ wéi zhī ér mò zhī yǐ yīng
上 禮 為 之 而 莫 之 以 應
highest ritual acts it and none it by-means-of respond

zé rǎng bì ér réng zhī
則 攘 臂 而 仍 之
then roll-up sleeve and still it

gù shī dào ér hòu dé
故 失 道 而 後 德
therefore lose way and after virtue

shī dé ér hòu rén
失 德 而 後 仁
lose virtue and after benevolence

shī rén ér hòu yì
失 仁 而 後 義
lose benevolence and after righteousness

shī yì ér hòu lǐ
失 義 而 後 禮
lose righteousness and after ritual

fú	lǐ	zhě	zhōng	xìn	zhī	bó
夫	禮	者	忠	信	之	薄
now	ritual	is	loyalty	trust	of	thin

ér	luàn	zhī	shǒu
而	亂	之	首
and	chaos	of	beginning

qián	shí	zhě	dào	zhī	huá
前	識	者	道	之	華
fore	knowledge	is	way	of	flower

ér	yú	zhī	shǐ
而	愚	之	始
and	foolishness	of	beginning

shì	yǐ	dà	zhàng	fū
是	以	大	丈	夫
this	therefore	great	person	man

chù	qí	hòu	bù	jū	qí	bó
處	其	厚	不	居	其	薄
dwells	its	thick	not	reside	its	thin

chù	qí	shí	bù	jū	qí	huá
處	其	實	不	居	其	華
dwells	its	fruit	not	reside	its	flower

gù	qù	bǐ	qǔ	cǐ
故	去	彼	取	此
therefore	reject	that	take	this

The highest virtue does not consider itself virtuous, thus it has virtue.
Lower virtue does not lose virtue, thus it lacks virtue.
The highest virtue acts without action and has no reason to act.
Lower virtue takes action and has reason to act.
Highest benevolence acts and has no reason to act.
Highest righteousness acts and has reason to act.
Highest ritual acts but none respond to it.
Thus they roll up their sleeves and throw it at them.
Therefore, when the Way is lost, virtue appears.
When virtue is lost, benevolence appears.
When benevolence is lost, righteousness appears.
When righteousness is lost, ritual appears.
Now, ritual is the thinning of loyalty and trust.
And the beginning of chaos.
Foreknowledge is the flower of the Way.
And the beginning of foolishness.
Therefore the great person.
Dwells in the substantial, not in the thin.
Dwells in the fruit, not in the flower.
Therefore rejects that and takes this.

Chapter 39

xī zhī dé yī zhě
昔 之 得 一 者
ancient of attain one those-who

tiān dé yī yī qīng
天 得 一 以 清
heaven attain one by-means-of pure

dì dé yī yī níng
地 得 一 以 寧
earth attain one by-means-of peaceful

shén dé yī yī líng
神 得 一 以 靈
spirit attain one by-means-of efficacious

gǔ dé yī yī yíng
谷 得 一 以 盈
valley attain one by-means-of full

wàn wù dé yī yī shēng
萬 物 得 一 以 生
ten-thousand things attain one by-means-of live

hóu	wáng	dé	yī	yǐ	wéi	tiān-xià	zhēn
侯	王	得	一	以	為	天下	貞
lord	king	attain	one	by-means-of	become	under-heaven	correct

qí	zhì	zhī
其	致	之
its	result	it

tiān	wú	yǐ	qīng	jiāng	kǒng	liè
天	無	以	清	將	恐	裂
heaven	without	by-means-of	pure	would	fear	split

dì	wú	yǐ	níng	jiāng	kǒng	fā
地	無	以	寧	將	恐	發
earth	without	by-means-of	peaceful	would	fear	burst

shén	wú	yǐ	líng	jiāng	kǒng	xiē
神	無	以	靈	將	恐	歇
spirit	without	by-means-of	efficacious	would	fear	cease

gǔ	wú	yǐ	yíng	jiāng	kǒng	jié
谷	無	以	盈	將	恐	竭
valley	without	by-means-of	full	would	fear	exhaust

wàn	wù	wú	yǐ	shēng	jiāng	kǒng	miè
萬	物	無	以	生	將	恐	滅
ten-thousand	things	without	by-means-of	live	would	fear	extinguish

hóu	wáng	wú	yǐ	guì	gāo	jiāng	kǒng	jué
侯	王	無	以	貴	高	將	恐	蹶
lord	king	without	by-means-of	noble	high	would	fear	stumble

gù	guì	yǐ	jiàn	wéi	běn
故	貴	以	賤	為	本
therefore	noble	by-means-of	humble	make	root

gāo	yǐ	xià	wéi	jī
高	以	下	為	基
high	by-means-of	low	make	foundation

shì	yǐ	hóu	wáng	zì	wèi	gū	guǎ
是	以	侯	王	自	謂	孤	寡
this	by-means-of	lord	king	self	call	orphaned	widowed

bù	gǔ
不	穀
not	worthy

cǐ	fēi	yǐ	jiàn	wéi	běn	yé
此	非	以	賤	為	本	邪
this	not	by-means-of	humble	make	root	is-it-not

fēi	hū
非	乎
not	question

gù	zhì	shù	yú	wú	yú
故	致	數	輿	無	輿
therefore	ultimate	count	carriage	no	carriage

bù	yù	lù	lù	rú	yù
不	欲	瑤	瑤	如	玉
not	desire	glossy	glossy	like	jade

luò	luò	rú	shí
珞	珞	如	石
plain	plain	like	stone

Those who attained the One in ancient times:
Heaven attained the One and became pure.
Earth attained the One and became stable.
Spirits attained the One and became powerful.
Valleys attained the One and became full.
Ten thousand things attained the One and came to life.
Lords and kings attained the One and became righteous rulers of the world.
This is what it leads to.
Without that which makes it pure, Heaven would risk splitting apart.
Without that which makes it stable, Earth would risk bursting open.
Without that which makes them powerful, spirits would risk fading away.
Without that which makes them full, valleys would risk drying up.
Without that which gives them life, the ten thousand things would risk
extinction.
Without that which makes them noble and high, lords and kings would risk
falling.
Therefore, the noble takes the humble as its root.
The high takes the low as its foundation.
Thus lords and kings call themselves 'orphaned,' 'widowed,' and 'unworthy.'
Is this not taking the humble as root?
Is it not so?
Therefore, the highest honor is no honor.
Do not desire to shine like jade,
But be as ordinary as stone.

Chapter 40

fǎn zhě dào zhī dòng
反 者 道 之 動
return that-which way of movement

ruò zhě dào zhī yòng
弱 者 道 之 用
weak that-which way of function

tiān xià wàn wù shēng yú yǒu
天 下 萬 物 生 於 有
heaven below ten-thousand things born from being

yǒu shēng yú wú
有 生 於 無
being born from non-being

Reversal is the movement of the Way.
Weakness is the function of the Way.
The ten thousand things under heaven are born from being.
Being is born from non-being.

Chapter 41

shàng	shì	wén	dào	qín	ér	xíng	zhī
上	士	聞	道	勤	而	行	之
upper	scholar	hear	way	diligent	and	practice	it

zhōng	shì	wén	dào	ruò	cún	ruò	wáng
中	士	聞	道	若	存	若	亡
middle	scholar	hear	way	as-if	exist	as-if	gone

xià	shì	wén	dào	dà	xiào	zhī
下	士	聞	道	大	笑	之
lower	scholar	hear	way	great	laugh	it

bù	xiào	bù	zú	yǐ	wéi	dào
不	笑	不	足	以	為	道
not	laugh	not	sufficient	by-means-of	become	way

gù	jiàn	yán	yǒu	zhī	yuē
故	建	言	有	之	曰
therefore	establish	words	have	it	say

míng	dào	ruò	mèi
明	道	若	昧
bright	way	as-if	dim

jìn	dào	ruò	tui
進	道	若	退
advance	way	as-if	retreat

yí	dào	ruò	lèi
夷	道	若	類
smooth	way	as-if	rough

shàng	dé	ruò	gǔ
上	德	若	谷
highest	virtue	as-if	valley

dà	bái	ruò	rǔ
大	白	若	辱
great	white	as-if	shame

guǎng	dé	ruò	bù	zú
廣	德	若	不	足
broad	virtue	as-if	not	sufficient

jiàn	dé	ruò	tōu
建	德	若	偷
establish	virtue	as-if	steal

zhì	zhēn	ruò	yú
質	真	若	渝
substance	true	as-if	change

dà	fāng	wú	yú
大	方	無	隅
great	square	without	corner

dà	qì	wǎn	chéng
大	器	晚	成
great	vessel	late	complete

dà	yīn	xī	shēng
大	音	希	聲
great	sound	rare	voice

dà	xiàng	wú	xíng
大	象	無	形
great	image	without	form

dào	yīn	wú	míng
道	隱	無	名
way	hidden	without	name

fú	wéi	dào	shàn	shǐ	qiě	shàn	chéng
夫	唯	道	善	始	且	善	成
indeed	only	way	good-at	beginning	and	good-at	complete

When a superior scholar hears of the Dao, they diligently practice it.
When a middling scholar hears of the Dao, it seems sometimes present,
sometimes absent.
When a lesser scholar hears of the Dao, they laugh greatly at it.
If it were not laughed at, it would not be sufficient to be the Dao.
Therefore the established sayings declare:
The bright way seems dim.
The advancing way seems retreating.
The smooth way seems rough.
The highest virtue is like a valley.
Great whiteness seems soiled.
Broad virtue seems insufficient.
Established virtue seems stolen.
True substance seems to change.
The great square has no corners.
The great vessel is late in completion.
The great sound is rarified in voice.
The great image has no form.
The Dao is hidden and nameless.
Yet it is the Dao alone that excels in giving and in completion.

Chapter 42

dào shēng yī
道 生 一
way generate one

yī shēng èr
一 生 二
one generate two

èr shēng sān
二 生 三
two generate three

sān shēng wàn wù
三 生 萬 物
three generate ten-thousand things

wàn wù fù yīn ér bào yáng
萬 物 負 陰 而 抱 陽
ten-thousand things carry yin and embrace yang

chōng qì yǐ wéi hé
沖 氣 以 為 和
vital energy by-means-of become harmony

rén	zhī	suǒ	wù
人	之	所	惡
people	of	that-which	detest

wéi	gū	guǎ	bù	gǔ
唯	孤	寡	不	穀
only	orphaned	widowed	not	grain

ér	wáng	gōng	yǐ	zì	chéng
而	王	公	以	自	稱
yet	king	duke	by-means-of	self	call

gù	wù
故	物
therefore	things

huò	sǔn	zhī	ér	yì
或	損	之	而	益
perhaps	decrease	it	yet	increase

huò	yì	zhī	ér	sǔn
或	益	之	而	損
perhaps	increase	it	yet	decrease

rén	zhī	suǒ	jiāo	wǒ	yì	jiāo	zhī
人	之	所	教	我	亦	教	之
people	of	that-which	teach	I	also	teach	it

qiáng	liáng	zhé	bù	dé	qí	sǐ
強	梁	者	不	得	其	死
strong	unyielding	one-who	not	obtain	their	death

wú	jiāng	yǐ	wéi	jiāo	fù
吾	將	以	為	教	父
I	will	by-means-of	make	teaching	father

The Dao gives birth to One
One gives birth to Two
Two gives birth to Three
Three gives birth to the ten thousand things
The ten thousand things carry yin and embrace yang
Through vital energy they achieve harmony
What people detest
Is being orphaned, widowed, and resourceless
Yet kings and dukes use these as their titles
Therefore, things
Sometimes through loss there is gain
Sometimes through gain there is loss
What others teach, I also teach
The forceful and unyielding do not meet their natural end
I will take this as the father of my teaching

Chapter 43

tiān xià zhī zhì róu
天 下 之 至 柔
heaven below of most soft

chí chēng tiān xià zhī zhì jiān
馳 騁 天 下 之 至 堅
gallop speed heaven below of most hard

wú yǒu rù wú jiān
無 有 入 無 間
not-have have enter not-have space

wú shì yǐ zhī wú wéi zhī yǒu yì
吾 是 以 知 無 為 之 有 益
I this by-means-of know not-have do of have benefit

bù yán zhī jiào
不 言 之 教
not speak of teach

wú wéi zhī yì
無 為 之 益
not-have do of benefit

tiān	xià	xī	jí	zhī
天	下	希	及	之
heaven	below	rare	reach	it

The softest thing in the universe
Races through the hardest thing in the universe
That which has no substance enters where there is no space
Through this I know the benefit of non-action
The teaching without words
The benefit of non-action
Few in the world can attain this

Chapter 44

míng	yǔ	shēn	shú	qīn
名	與	身	孰	親
name	and	self	which	close

shēn	yǔ	huò	shú	duō
身	與	貨	孰	多
self	and	goods	which	more

dé	yǔ	wáng	shú	bìng
得	與	亡	孰	病
gain	and	lose	which	illness

shèn	ài	bì	dà	fèi
甚	愛	必	大	費
excessive	love	must	great	cost

duō	cáng	bì	hòu	wáng
多	藏	必	厚	亡
much	store	must	heavy	lose

zhī	zú	bù	rǔ
知	足	不	辱
know	enough	not	shame

zhī	zhǐ	bù	dài
知	止	不	殆
know	stop	not	danger

kě	yǐ	cháng	jiǔ
可	以	長	久
can	by-means-of	long	lasting

Between name and self, which is closer?
Between self and wealth, which is more?
Between gain and loss, which brings more pain?
Excessive love must lead to great cost.
Much hoarding must lead to heavy loss.
Knowing contentment avoids shame.
Knowing when to stop avoids danger.
Thus can one endure long.

Chapter 45

dà	chéng	ruò	quē
大	成	若	缺
great	completion	like	lacking

qí	yòng	bù	bì
其	用	不	弊
its	use	not	worn-out

dà	yíng	ruò	zhōng
大	盈	若	盅
great	fullness	like	empty

qí	yòng	bù	qióng
其	用	不	窮
its	use	not	exhausted

dà	zhí	ruò	qū
大	直	若	屈
great	straight	like	bent

dà	qiǎo	ruò	zhuō
大	巧	若	拙
great	skilled	like	clumsy

dà	biàn	ruò	nè
大	辯	若	訥
great	eloquence	like	stuttering

zào	shèng	hán
躁	勝	寒
movement	overcomes	cold

jìng	shèng	rè
靜	勝	熱
stillness	overcomes	heat

qīng	jìng	wéi	tiān	xià	zhèng
清	靜	為	天	下	正
pure	still	becomes	heaven	below	proper

Great perfection seems incomplete.
Yet its use is inexhaustible.
Great fullness seems empty.
Yet its use is endless.
Great straightness seems bent.
Great skill seems awkward.
Great eloquence seems stuttering.
Movement overcomes cold.
Stillness overcomes heat.
Pure tranquility becomes the way of heaven.

Chapter 46

tiān	xià	yǒu	dào
天	下	有	道
heaven	below	have	way

què	zǒu	mǎ	yǐ	fèn
卻	走	馬	以	糞
retire	running	horse	by-means-of	manure

tiān	xià	wú	dào
天	下	無	道
heaven	below	not-have	way

róng	mǎ	shēng	yú	jiāo
戎	馬	生	於	郊
war	horse	born	at	outskirts

zuì	mò	dà	yú	kě	yù
罪	莫	大	於	可	欲
crime	none	greater	than	permissible	desire

huò	mò	dà	yú	bù	zhī	zú
禍	莫	大	於	不	知	足
disaster	none	greater	than	not	know	enough

jiù	mò	dà	yú	yù	de
咎	莫	大	於	欲	得
fault	none	greater	than	desire	obtain

gù	zhī	zú	zhī	zú	cháng	zú	yī
故	知	足	之	足	常	足	矣
therefore	know	enough	of	enough	constant	enough	indeed

When the Way prevails in the world,
Retiring horses are used for fertilizing fields.
When the Way is absent from the world,
War horses breed in the suburbs.
No crime is greater than yielding to desire.
No disaster is greater than not knowing contentment.
No fault is greater than wanting to acquire more.
Therefore, knowing contentment's contentment is eternal contentment.

Chapter 47

bù chū hù
不 出 戶
not go-out door

yǐ zhī tiān xià
以 知 天 下
by-means-of know heaven below

bù kuī yǒu
不 闕 牖
not peek window

yǐ zhī tiān dào
以 知 天 道
by-means-of know heaven way

qí chū mí yuǎn
其 出 彌 遠
its go-out increasingly far

qí zhī mí shǎo
其 知 彌 少
its know increasingly little

shì	yǐ	shèng	rén
是	以	聖	人
this	by-means-of	sage	person

bù	xíng	ér	zhī
不	行	而	知
not	walk	yet	know

bù	jiàn	ér	míng
不	見	而	名
not	see	yet	name

bù	wéi	ér	chéng
不	為	而	成
not	do	yet	complete

Without going beyond one's door
One can know the world
Without peering through one's window
One can know the Way of Heaven
The further one goes
The less one knows
Therefore the sage
Without moving, yet knows
Without seeing, yet names
Without acting, yet accomplishes

Chapter 48

wéi xué zhě rì yì
為 學 者 日 益
engage-in learning one-who day increase

wéi dào zhě rì sǔn
為 道 者 日 損
engage-in dao one-who day decrease

sǔn zhī yòu sǔn
損 之 又 損
decrease it again decrease

yǐ zhì yú wú wéi
以 至 於 無 為
by-means-of arrive at non action

wú wéi ér wú bù wéi
無 為 而 無 不 為
non action yet nothing not do

qǔ tiān xià cháng yǐ wú shì
取 天 下 常 以 無 事
take heaven below always by-means-of non affairs

jí qí yǒu shì
及 其 有 事
when it have affairs

bù zú yǐ qǔ tiān xià
不 足 以 取 天 下
not sufficient by-means-of take heaven below

Those who pursue learning gain more each day.
Those who pursue the Dao reduce more each day.
Reduce and reduce again.
Until one reaches non-action.
Through non-action, nothing is left undone.
The world is gained by constant non-interference.
As soon as there is interference,
One becomes inadequate to gain the world.

Chapter 49

shèng rén wú cháng xīn
聖 人 無 常 心
sage person without constant heart

yǐ bǎi xìng xīn wéi xīn
以 百 姓 心 為 心
by-means-of hundred surnames heart make heart

shàn zhě wú shàn zhī
善 者 吾 善 之
good those I good them

bù shàn zhě wú yì shàn zhī
不 善 者 吾 亦 善 之
not good those I also good them

dé shàn
德 善
virtue good

xìn zhě wú xìn zhī
信 者 吾 信 之
trust those I trust them

bù xìn zhě wú yì xìn zhī
不 信 者 吾 亦 信 之
not trust those I also trust them

dé xìn
德 信
virtue trust

shèng rén zài tiān xià xī xī
聖 人 在 天 下 歙 歙
sage person at heaven below careful careful

yān wéi tiān xià hún qí xīn
焉 為 天 下 渾 其 心
therefore for heaven below merge their heart

bǎi xìng jiē zhù qí ěr mù
百 姓 皆 注 其 耳 目
hundred surnames all focus their ears eyes

shèng rén jiē hái zhī
聖 人 皆 孩 之
sage person all child them

The sage has no fixed mind-heart
Takes the heart-mind of the common people as their own heart-mind
To those who are good, I am good to them
To those who are not good, I am also good to them
This is the virtue of goodness
To those who are trustworthy, I trust them
To those who are not trustworthy, I also trust them
This is the virtue of trust
The sage dwells under heaven carefully and attentively
For this reason merges their heart-mind with all under heaven
The common people all focus their ears and eyes
The sage treats them all as children

Chapter 50

chū	shēng	rù	sǐ
出	生	入	死
emerge	life	enter	death

shēng	zhī	tú	shí	yǒu	sān
生	之	徒	十	有	三
life	of	followers	ten	have	three

sǐ	zhī	tú	shí	yǒu	sān
死	之	徒	十	有	三
death	of	followers	ten	have	three

rén	zhī	shēng	dòng	zhī	sǐ	dì
人	之	生	動	之	死	地
human	of	life	movement	of	death	ground

yì	shí	yǒu	sān
亦	十	有	三
also	ten	have	three

fú	hé	gù
夫	何	故
now	what	reason

yǐ	qí	shēng	shēng	zhī	hòu
以	其	生	生	之	厚
by-means-of	their	live	life	of	thick

gài	wén	shàn	shè	shēng	zhě
蓋	聞	善	攝	生	者
indeed	hear	good-at	nurture	life	one-who

líng	xíng	bù	yù	sì	hǔ
陵	行	不	遇	兕	虎
land	travel	not	meet	rhinoceros	tiger

rù	jūn	bù	bèi	jiǎ	bīng
入	軍	不	被	甲	兵
enter	army	not	wear	armor	weapon

sì	wú	suǒ	tóu	qí	jiǎo
兕	無	所	投	其	角
rhinoceros	no	place	thrust	its	horn

hǔ	wú	suǒ	cuò	qí	zhǎo
虎	無	所	措	其	爪
tiger	no	place	put	its	claw

bīng	wú	suǒ	róng	qí	rèn
兵	無	所	容	其	刃
weapon	no	place	contain	its	blade

fú hé gù
夫 何 故
now what reason

yǐ qí wú sǐ dì
以 其 無 死 地
by-means-of their no death ground

Emerging into life, entering into death.
The followers of life are thirteen.
The followers of death are thirteen.
In human life, the places of movement leading to death-ground are also thirteen.
Also thirteen.
Now, why is this so?
Because of the intensity with which they live life.
Indeed, I have heard that one who is good at nurturing life
Traveling on land, meets neither rhinoceros nor tiger.
Entering battle, needs no armor or weapons.
The rhinoceros finds nowhere to thrust its horn.
The tiger finds nowhere to place its claws.
Weapons find nowhere to lodge their blades.
Now, why is this so?
Because in them there is no death-ground.

Chapter 51

dào shēng zhī
道 生 之
way give-birth them

dé xù zhī
德 畜 之
virtue nurture them

wù xíng zhī
物 形 之
matter shape them

shì chéng zhī
勢 成 之
circumstances complete them

shì yǐ wàn wù
是 以 萬 物
this by-means-of ten-thousand things

mò bù zūn dào ér guì dé
莫 不 尊 道 而 貴 德
none not revere way and value virtue

dào zhī zūn
 道 之 尊
 way of revere

dé zhī guì
 德 之 貴
 virtue of value

fú mò zhī mìng
 夫 莫 之 命
 indeed none them command

ér cháng zì rán
 而 常 自 然
 yet always self so

gù dào shēng zhī dé xù zhī
 故 道 生 之 德 畜 之
 therefore way give-birth them virtue nurture them

zhǎng zhī yù zhī
 長 之 育 之
 grow them rear them

tíng zhī dú zhī
 亭 之 毒 之
 stabilize them mature them

yǎng	zhī	fù	zhī
養	之	覆	之
nourish	them	protect	them

shēng	ér	bù	yǒu
生	而	不	有
give-birth	yet	not	possess

wéi	ér	bù	shì
為	而	不	恃
do	yet	not	rely-on

zhǎng	ér	bù	zǎi
長	而	不	宰
grow	yet	not	control

shì	wéi	xuán	dé
是	謂	玄	德
this	called	profound	virtue

The Dao gives birth to them
Virtue nurtures them
Matter shapes them
Circumstances complete them
Therefore among all things
None fail to revere the Dao and honor virtue
The Dao's reverence
Virtue's value
Indeed none commands them
Yet they are naturally so
Thus the Dao gives birth and virtue nurtures
Grows them and develops them
Stabilizes them and matures them
Nourishes them and protects them
Gives life without possessing
Acts without depending
Leads without controlling
This is called profound virtue

Chapter 52

tiān xià yǒu shǐ
天 下 有 始
heaven below has beginning

yǐ wéi tiān xià mǔ
以 為 天 下 母
by-means-of become heaven below mother

jì dé qí mǔ
既 得 其 母
already obtain its mother

yǐ zhī qí zǐ
以 知 其 子
by-means-of know its child

jì zhī qí zǐ
既 知 其 子
already know its child

fù shǒu qí mǔ
復 守 其 母
return guard its mother

mò	shēn	bù	dài
沒	身	不	殆
end	body	not	dangerous

sè	qí	duì	bì	qí	mén
塞	其	兌	閉	其	門
block	its	opening	close	its	door

zhōng	shēn	bù	qín
終	身	不	勤
end	body	not	toil

kāi	qí	duì	jì	qí	shì
開	其	兌	濟	其	事
open	its	opening	manage	its	affairs

zhōng	shēn	bù	jiù
終	身	不	救
end	body	not	save

jiàn	xiǎo	yuē	míng
見	小	曰	明
see	small	called	bright

shǒu	róu	yuē	qiáng
守	柔	曰	強
guard	soft	called	strong

yòng	qí	guāng	fù	guī	qí	míng
用	其	光	復	歸	其	明
use	its	light	return	return-to	its	brightness

wú	yí	shēn	yǎng
無	遺	身	殃
not	leave	body	disaster

shì	wèi	xí	cháng
是	謂	習	常
this	called	practice	constant

The world has a beginning
Which is regarded as the mother of all things
Having found the mother
Through this know the child
Having known the child
Return to guard the mother
To the end of life, there will be no danger
Block the passages, shut the doors
To the end of life, there will be no toil
Open the passages, attend to affairs
To the end of life, there will be no salvation
Seeing the small is called enlightenment
Keeping to gentleness is called strength
Use the light, return again to brightness
Leave no misfortune upon the body
This is called practicing the constant

Chapter 53

shǐ wǒ jiè rán yǒu zhī
使 我 介 然 有 知
let I small thus have knowledge

xíng yú dà dào
行 於 大 道
walk upon great way

wéi yī shì wèi
唯 迤 是 畏
only deviate this fear

dà dào shèn yí
大 道 甚 夷
great way very level

ér mín hào jīng
而 民 好 徑
yet people prefer shortcut

cháo shèn chú
朝 甚 除
court very clear

tián	shèn	wú
田	甚	蕪
field	very	overgrown

cāng	shèn	xū
倉	甚	虛
granary	very	empty

fú	wéncǎi
服	文綵
wear	ornate-clothes

dài	lì	jiàn
帶	利	劍
carry	sharp	sword

yàn	yǐn	shí
厭	飲	食
satiated	drink	food

cái	huò	yǒu	yú
財	貨	有	餘
wealth	goods	have	excess

shì	wèi	dào	kuā
是	謂	盜	夸
this	called	robber	boast

fēi	dào	yě	zāi
非	道	也	哉
not	way	indeed	emphasis

Let me have just a little knowledge.
Walking on the great Way.
Only the deviation is fearsome.
The great Way is very level.
Yet people prefer shortcuts.
The court is very splendid.
The fields are very weedy.
The granaries are very empty.
Wearing ornate clothing.
Carrying sharp swords.
Gorged with food and drink.
Wealth and goods in excess.
This is called robber-boasting.
Truly not the Way!

Chapter 54

shàn	jiàn	zhě	bù	bá
善	建	者	不	拔
good-at	establish	one-who	not	uproot

shàn	bào	zhě	bù	tuō
善	抱	者	不	脫
good-at	embrace	one-who	not	slip-away

zǐ	sūn	yǐ	jì	sì	bù	chuò
子	孫	以	祭	祀	不	輟
child	grandchild	by-means-of	sacrifice	worship	not	cease

xiū	zhī	—	shēn	qí	dé	nǎi	zhēn
修	之	—	身	其	德	乃	真
cultivate	it		person	its	virtue	then	true

xiū	zhī	—	jiā	qí	dé	nǎi	yú
修	之	—	家	其	德	乃	餘
cultivate	it		family	its	virtue	then	abundant

xiū	zhī	—	xiāng	qí	dé	nǎi	cháng
修	之	—	鄉	其	德	乃	長
cultivate	it		village	its	virtue	then	long-lasting

xiū	zhī	—	guó	qí	dé	nǎi	fèng
修	之	—	國	其	德	乃	豐
cultivate	it		state	its	virtue	then	prosperous

xiū	zhī	—	tiān	xià	qí	dé	nǎi	pǔ
修	之	—	天	下	其	德	乃	普
cultivate	it		heaven	below	its	virtue	then	universal

gù	yǐ	shēn	guān	shēn
故	以	身	觀	身
therefore	by-means-of	person	observe	person

yǐ	jiā	guān	jiā
以	家	觀	家
by-means-of	family	observe	family

yǐ	xiāng	guān	xiāng
以	鄉	觀	鄉
by-means-of	village	observe	village

yǐ	guó	guān	guó
以	國	觀	國
by-means-of	state	observe	state

yǐ	tiān	xià	guān	tiān	xià
以	天	下	觀	天	下
by-means-of	heaven	below	observe	heaven	below

wú hé yǐ zhī tiān xià rán zāi
吾 何 以 知 天 下 然 哉
I how by-means-of know heaven below thus indeed

yǐ cǐ
以 此
by-means-of this

What is well established will not be uprooted.
What is well embraced will not slip away.
Descendants will continue their ancestral sacrifices without cessation.
Cultivate it in your person, and the virtue becomes genuine.
Cultivate it in the family, and the virtue becomes abundant.
Cultivate it in the village, and the virtue becomes lasting.
Cultivate it in the state, and the virtue becomes prosperous.
Cultivate it in the world, and the virtue becomes universal.
Therefore, observe the person through the person.
Observe the family through the family.
Observe the village through the village.
Observe the state through the state.
Observe the world through the world.
How do I know the world is thus?
Through this.

Chapter 55

hán	dé	zhī	hòu	zhě
含	德	之	厚	者
contain	virtue	of	thick	one-who

bǐ	yú	chì	zǐ
比	於	赤	子
compare	to	red	child

fēng	chài	huī	shé	bù	shì
蜂	蠆	虺	蛇	不	螫
wasp	scorpion	viper	snake	not	sting

měng	shòu	bù	jù
猛	獸	不	據
fierce	beast	not	seize

jué	niǎo	bù	tuán
攫	鳥	不	搏
predatory	bird	not	strike

gǔ	ruò	jīn	róu	ér	wò	gù
骨	弱	筋	柔	而	握	固
bone	weak	sinew	soft	yet	grip	firm

wèi	zhī	pīn	mù	zhī	hé	ér	xuān	zuò
未	知	牝	牡	之	合	而	腴	作
not-yet	know	female	male	of	union	yet	vital-force	arise

jīng	zhī	zhì	yě
精	之	至	也
essence	of	ultimate	indeed

zhōng	rì	háo	ér	bù	shà
終	日	號	而	不	嗟
whole	day	cry	yet	not	hoarse

hé	zhī	zhì	yě
和	之	至	也
harmony	of	ultimate	indeed

zhī	hé	yuē	cháng
知	和	曰	常
know	harmony	called	constant

zhī	cháng	yuē	míng
知	常	曰	明
know	constant	called	bright

yì	shēng	yuē	xiáng
益	生	曰	祥
benefit	life	called	fortune

xīn	shǐ	qì	yuē	qiáng
心	使	氣	曰	強
heart-mind	control	breath	called	strong

wù	zhuàng	zé	lǎo
物	壯	則	老
thing	strong	then	old

wèi	zhī	bù	dào
謂	之	不	道
called	it	not	way

bù	dào	zǎo	yǐ
不	道	早	已
not	way	early	end

One who possesses profound virtue
Is comparable to a newborn child
Wasps, scorpions, vipers, and snakes do not sting it
Fierce beasts do not seize it
Birds of prey do not strike it
Bones weak, sinews soft, yet its grip is firm
Not yet knowing the union of male and female, yet its vitality manifests
This is the perfection of essence
Crying all day without becoming hoarse
This is the perfection of harmony
To know harmony is called constancy
To know constancy is called enlightenment
Enriching life is called fortune
Mind controlling breath is called force
When things mature they become old
This is called not following the Way
Not following the Way leads to early death

Chapter 56

zhī zhě bù yán
知 者 不 言
know one-who not speak

yán zhě bù zhī
言 者 不 知
speak one-who not know

sāi qí duì bì qí mén
塞 其 兌 閉 其 門
block its opening close its gate

cuò qí ruì
挫 其 銳
blunt its sharp

jiě qí fēn
解 其 紛
untie its tangled

hé qí guāng
和 其 光
harmonize its light

tóng qí chén
同 其 塵
unite its dust

shì wèi xuán tóng
是 謂 玄 同
this called mysterious unity

gù bù kě dé ér qīn
故 不 可 得 而 親
therefore not can obtain and intimate

bù kě dé ér shū
不 可 得 而 疏
not can obtain and distant

bù kě dé ér lì
不 可 得 而 利
not can obtain and benefit

bù kě dé ér hài
不 可 得 而 害
not can obtain and harm

bù kě dé ér guì
不 可 得 而 貴
not can obtain and value

bù kě dé ér jiàn
不 可 得 而 賤
not can obtain and despise

gù wéi tiān xià guì
故 為 天 下 貴
therefore become heaven under valued

Those who know do not speak.
Those who speak do not know.
Block the openings, shut the gates.
Blunt the sharpness.
Untangle the knots.
Soften the glare.
Merge with the dust.
This is called mysterious unity.
Therefore one cannot get close to it.
One cannot keep it at a distance.
One cannot benefit from it.
One cannot harm it.
One cannot honor it.
One cannot debase it.
Therefore it is valued by all under heaven.

Chapter 57

yǐ zhèng zhì guó
以 正 治 國
by-means-of correct govern country

yǐ qí yòng bīng
以 奇 用 兵
by-means-of unusual use troops

yǐ wú shì qǔ tiān xià
以 無 事 取 天 下
by-means-of without affairs take heaven below

wú hé yǐ zhī qí rán zāi
吾 何 以 知 其 然 哉
I how by-means-of know its so indeed

yǐ cǐ
以 此
by-means-of this

tiān xià duō jì huì
天 下 多 忌 諱
heaven below many taboo avoid

ér	mín	mí	pín
而	民	彌	貧
yet	people	increasingly	poor

mín	duō	lì	qì
民	多	利	器
people	many	sharp	tools

guó	jiā	zī	hūn
而	國	家	滋
yet	country	family	grow

rén	duō	zhī	qiǎo
人	多	知	巧
people	many	knowledge	skill

qí	wù	zī	qǐ
而	奇	物	滋
yet	strange	things	grow

fǎ	wù	zī	zhāng
法	物	滋	章
law	things	grow	manifest

dào	zéi	duō	yǒu
盜	賊	多	有
thief	robber	many	exist

	shèng	rén	yún
故	聖	人	云
therefore	sage	person	say

wǒ	wú	wéi	ér	mín	zì	huà
我	無	為	而	民	自	化
I	without	action	yet	people	self	transform

wǒ	hào	jìng	ér	mín	zì	zhèng
我	好	靜	而	民	自	正
I	love	quiet	yet	people	self	correct

wǒ	wú	shì	ér	mín	zì	fù
我	無	事	而	民	自	富
I	without	affairs	yet	people	self	wealthy

wǒ	wú	yù	ér	mín	zì	pǔ
我	無	欲	而	民	自	樸
I	without	desire	yet	people	self	simple

By means of the correct/orthodox way to govern the country

By means of the unorthodox to deploy troops

By means of non-action to gain the world

How do I know it is so?

Through this:

When the world has many prohibitions

The people become increasingly poor

When people have many sharp weapons

The state grows increasingly confused

When people have much knowledge and skill

Strange things increasingly arise

As laws and regulations multiply

Thieves and robbers become more numerous

Therefore the sage says

I practice non-action and the people transform themselves

I love quietude and the people rectify themselves

I take no action and the people prosper by themselves

I have no desires and the people become simple by themselves

Chapter 58

qí	zhèng	mèn	mèn
其	政	悶	悶
their	governance	dull	dull

qí	mín	chún	chún
其	民	淳	淳
their	people	pure	pure

qí	zhèng	chá	chá
其	政	察	察
their	governance	examine	examine

qí	mín	quē	quē
其	民	缺	缺
their	people	lacking	lacking

huò	xī	fú	zhī	suǒ	yī
禍	兮	福	之	所	倚
misfortune	ah	fortune	of	that-which	lean-on

fú	xī	huò	zhī	suǒ	fú
福	兮	禍	之	所	伏
fortune	ah	misfortune	of	that-which	hide

shú	zhī	qí	jí
孰	知	其	極
who	know	their	limit

qí	wú	zhèng
其	無	正
its	not-have	proper

zhèng	fù	wéi	qí
正	復	為	奇
proper	return	become	strange

shàn	fù	wéi	yāo
善	復	為	妖
good	return	become	evil

rén	zhī	mí
人	之	迷
people	of	delusion

qí	rì	gù	jiǔ
其	日	固	久
its	days	indeed	long

shì	yǐ	shèng	rén
是	以	聖	人
this	by-means-of	sage	person

fāng	ér	bù	gē
方	而	不	割
square	yet	not	cut

lián	ér	bù	guì
廉	而	不	劇
sharp	yet	not	pierce

zhí	ér	bù	sì
直	而	不	肆
straight	yet	not	unbridled

guāng	ér	bù	yào
光	而	不	耀
bright	yet	not	dazzle

Their governance is dull and inactive.
Their people are simple and honest.
Their governance is scrutinizing and strict.
Their people are deficient and wanting.
Misfortune! It is what fortune leans upon.
Fortune! It is where misfortune hides.
Who knows their limits?
There is no fixed standard.
The proper returns to become the strange.
The good returns to become the ominous.
People's delusion!
Its days have indeed been long.
Therefore the sage is:
Square but does not cut.
Sharp but does not pierce.
Straight but does not extend too far.
Bright but does not dazzle.

Chapter 59

zhì rén shì tiān
治 人 事 天
govern people serve heaven

mò ruò sè
莫 若 嗇
nothing like frugal

fū wéi sè
夫 唯 嗇
indeed only frugal

shì wèi zǎo fú
是 謂 早 服
this called early submit

zǎo fú wèi zhī chóng jī dé
早 服 謂 之 重 積 德
early submit called it repeatedly accumulate virtue

chóng jī dé
重 積 德
repeatedly accumulate virtue

zé	wú	bù	kè
則	無	不	克
then	nothing	not	overcome

wú	bù	kè
無	不	克
nothing	not	overcome

zé	mò	zhī	qí	jí
則	莫	知	其	極
then	none	know	its	limit

mò	zhī	qí	jí
莫	知	其	極
none	know	its	limit

kě	yǐ	yǒu	guó
可	以	有	國
can	by-means-of	have	state

yǒu	guó	zhī	mǔ
有	國	之	母
have	state	of	mother

kě	yǐ	cháng	jiǔ
可	以	長	久
can	by-means-of	long	endure

shì	wèi	shēn	gēn	gù	dī
是	謂	深	根	固	抵
this	called	deep	root	firm	foundation

cháng	shēng	jiǔ	shì	zhī	dào
長	生	久	視	之	道
long	life	lasting	vision	of	way

In governing people and serving heaven
Nothing compares to frugality
For only through frugality
This is called early submission
Early submission means repeatedly accumulating virtue
Repeatedly accumulating virtue
Then there is nothing that cannot be overcome
When there is nothing that cannot be overcome
Then no one knows one's limits
When no one knows one's limits
One can possess the state
Possessing the mother of the state
One can long endure
This is called deep roots and firm foundation
This is the way of long life and lasting vision

Chapter 60

zhì	dà	guó	ruò	pēng	xiǎo	xiān
治	大	國	若	烹	小	鮮
govern	great	country	like	cook	small	fish

yǐ	dào	lì	tiān	xià
以	道	莅	天	下
by-means-of	way	oversee	heaven	below

qí	guǐ	bù	shén
其	鬼	不	神
their	spirits	not	divine

fēi	qí	guǐ	bù	shén
非	其	鬼	不	神
not	their	spirits	not	divine

qí	shén	bù	shāng	rén
其	神	不	傷	人
their	divine	not	harm	person

fēi	qí	shén	bù	shāng	rén
非	其	神	不	傷	人
not	their	divine	not	harm	person

shèng	rén	yì	bù	shāng	rén
聖	人	亦	不	傷	人
sage	person	also	not	harm	person

fú	liǎng	bù	xiāng	shāng
夫	兩	不	相	傷
thus	two	not	mutually	harm

gù	dé	jiāo	guī	yān
故	德	交	歸	焉
therefore	virtue	exchange	return	therein

Governing a large country is like cooking small fish.
When using the Way to oversee the world,
Their spirits will not be supernatural.
It's not that their spirits are not supernatural.
Their divinity will not harm people.
It's not that their divinity cannot harm people.
The sage also does not harm people.
When these two do not harm each other,
Therefore their virtues merge and return as one.

Chapter 61

dà guó zhě xià liú
大 國 者 下 流
great state one-who lower flow

tiān xià zhī jiāo
天 下 之 交
heaven below of intersection

tiān xià zhī pīn
天 下 之 牝
heaven below of female

pīn cháng yǐ jìng shèng mù
牝 常 以 靜 勝 牡
female always by-means-of stillness overcome male

yǐ jìng wéi xià
以 靜 為 下
by-means-of stillness become lower

gù dà guó yǐ xià xiǎo guó
故 大 國 以 下 小 國
therefore great state by-means-of lower small state

zé qǔ xiǎo guó
則 取 小 國
then gain small state

xiǎo guó yǐ xià dà guó
小 國 以 下 大 國
small state by-means-of lower great state

zé qǔ yú dà guó
則 取 於 大 國
then gain by great state

gù huò xià yǐ qǔ
故 或 下 以 取
therefore some lower by-means-of gain

huò xià ér qǔ
或 下 而 取
some lower and gain

dà guó bù guò yù jiān chù rén
大 國 不 過 欲 兼 畜 人
great state not exceed desire unite nurture people

xiǎo guó bù guò yù rù shì rén
小 國 不 過 欲 入 事 人
small state not exceed desire enter serve people

fú	liǎng	zhě	gè	dé	qí	suǒ	yù
夫	兩	者	各	得	其	所	欲
indeed	both	ones	each	obtain	their	that-which	desire

dà	zhě	yí	wéi	xià
大	者	宜	為	下
great	one	should	become	lower

A great state is like the lower reaches of a river.
It is the meeting point of all under heaven.
It is the feminine principle of all under heaven.
The female always overcomes the male through stillness.
Through stillness, she takes the lower position.
Therefore when a great state lowers itself before a small state,
It will win over the small state.
When a small state lowers itself before a great state,
It will be taken by the great state.
Therefore, some lower themselves to gain,
And some lower themselves and gain.
The great state desires nothing more than to gather and nurture people.
The small state desires nothing more than to serve others.
Thus both get what they desire.
The greater one should take the lower position.

Chapter 62

dào zhě wàn wù zhī ào
道 者 萬 物 之 奧
way that-which ten-thousand things of mystery

shàn rén zhī bǎo
善 人 之 寶
good person of treasure

bù shàn rén zhī suǒ bǎo
不 善 人 之 所 保
not good person of that-which protect

měi yán kě yǐ shì
美 言 可 以 市
beautiful words can by-means-of market

zūn xíng kě yǐ jiā rén
尊 行 可 以 加 人
honorable conduct can by-means-of add-to person

rén zhī bù shàn
人 之 不 善
person of not good

hé qì zhī yǒu
何 棄 之 有
how abandon them have

gù lì tiān zǐ
故 立 天 子
therefore establish heaven son

zhì sān gōng
置 三 公
install three ministers

sui yǒu gǒngbì yǐ xiān sì mǎ
雖 有 拱 壁 以 先 駟 馬
although have jade-disc by-means-of advance four-horses

bù rú zuò jìn cǐ dào
不 如 坐 進 此 道
not like sit advance this way

gǔ zhī suǒyǐ guì cǐ dào zhě hé
古 之 所 以 貴 此 道 者 何
ancient of reason-why value this way one-who what

bù yuē
不 曰
not say

yǐ	qiú	dé
以	求	得
by-means-of	seek	obtain

yǒu	zuì	yǐ	miǎn	xié
有	罪	以	免	邪
have	guilt	by-means-of	avoid	wrong

gù	wéi	tiān	xià	guì
故	為	天	下	貴
therefore	become	heaven	under	valuable

The Dao is the mysterious source of all things.
It is the treasure of the virtuous person.
It is what protects those who are not virtuous.
Beautiful words can be traded in the marketplace.
Noble conduct can earn respect from others.
When people are not good,
How can they be abandoned?
Therefore, when establishing the Son of Heaven
And installing the Three Ministers,
Though one might present jade discs and four-horse teams,
It is not as good as sitting and offering this Dao.
Why did the ancients treasure this Dao?
Did they not say:
Through it one can obtain what one seeks
And the guilty can escape punishment?
Therefore it is valued by all under heaven.

Chapter 63

wéi wú wéi
為 無 為
do without doing

shì wú shì
事 無 事
handle without affairs

wèi wú wèi
味 無 味
taste without flavor

dà xiǎo duō shǎo
大 小 多 少
great small many few

bào yuàn yǐ dé
報 怨 以 德
repay enmity by-means-of virtue

tú nán yú qí yì
圖 難 於 其 易
plan difficult at its easy

wéi dà yú qí xì
為 大 於 其 細
act great at its small

tiān-xià nán shì bì zuò yú yì
天 下 難 事 必 作 於 易
under-heaven difficult affairs must arise from easy

tiān-xià dà shì bì zuò yú xì
天 下 大 事 必 作 於 細
under-heaven great affairs must arise from small

shì-yǐ shèng-rén zhōng bù wéi dà
是 以 聖 人 終 不 為 大
therefore sage end not do great

gù néng chéng qí dà
故 能 成 其 大
therefore can accomplish their greatness

fú qīng nuò bì guǎ xìn
夫 輕 諾 必 寡 信
indeed light promise must few trust

duō yì bì duō nán
多 易 必 多 難
much easy must much difficult

shì-yì	shèng-rén	yóu	nán	zhī		
是	以	聖	人	猶	難	之
therefore		sage		still	difficult	it

gù	zhōng	wú	nán	yī
故	終	無	難	矣
therefore	end	without	difficulty	indeed

Practice non-action.
Attend to non-affairs.
Taste the tasteless.
Consider great and small, many and few.
Repay enmity with virtue.
Plan for difficulty while it is still easy.
Act on the great while it is still small.
All difficult things in the world must arise from the easy.
All great things in the world must arise from the small.
Therefore the sage never attempts the great.
And thus can accomplish the great.
One who makes promises lightly surely lacks trust.
Much ease surely brings much difficulty.
Therefore the sage considers things difficult.
And therefore never encounters difficulty.

Chapter 64

qí	ān	yì	chí
其	安	易	持
its	peace	easy	maintain

qí	wèi	zhào	yì	móu
其	未	兆	易	謀
its	not-yet	show-signs	easy	plan

qí	cuì	yì	pàn
其	脆	易	泮
its	brittle	easy	break

qí	wēi	yì	sàn
其	微	易	散
its	minute	easy	scatter

wéi	zhī	yú	wèi	yǒu
為	之	於	未	有
act	it	at	not-yet	exist

zhì	zhī	yú	wèi	luàn
治	之	於	未	亂
manage	it	at	not-yet	chaos

hé bào zhī mù shēng yú háo mò
合抱 之 木 生 於 毫末
arms-embrace of tree grow from tiny-sprout

jiǔ céng zhī tái qǐ yú lěi tǔ
九 層 之 臺 起 於 累土
nine story of tower rise from piled-earth

qiān lǐ zhī xíng shǐ yú zú xià
千 里 之 行 始 於 足下
thousand li of journey begin at under-feet

wéi zhě bài zhī
為 者 敗 之
act one-who ruin it

zhí zhě shī zhī
執 者 失 之
grasp one-who lose it

shì yǐ shèng rén
是以 聖人
therefore sage

wú wéi gù wú bài
無 為 故 無 敗
without action therefore without fail

wú zhí gù wú shī
無 執 故 無 失
without grasp therefore without lose

mín zhī cóng shì cháng yú jī chéng ér bài
民 之 從事 常 於 幾成 而 敗
people of undertake often at almost-complete yet fail
zhī
之
it

shèn zhōng rú shǐ
慎 終 如 始
careful end like beginning

zé wú bài shì
則 無 敗 事
then no fail matter

shì yǐ shèng rén
是以 聖人
therefore sage

yù bù yù
欲 不 欲
desire not desire

bù	guì	nán	dé	zhī	huò
不	貴	難	得	之	貨
not	value	difficult	obtain	of	goods

xué	bù	xué
學	不	學
learn	not	learn

fù	zhòng	rén	zhī	suǒ	guò
復	眾	人	之	所	過
return	many	people	of	that-which	pass-by

yǐ	fù	wàn wù	zhī	zì rán
以	輔	萬物	之	自然
by-means-of	assist	ten-thousand-things	of	natural-way

ér	bù	gǎn	wéi
而	不	敢	為
yet	not	dare	act

What is at peace is easily maintained.
What has not yet shown signs is easily planned for.
What is brittle is easily broken.
What is minute is easily scattered.
Act on things before they exist.
Manage them before they are chaotic.
A tree that fills the arms' embrace grows from a tiny sprout.
A nine-story tower rises from a pile of earth.
A journey of a thousand li begins beneath one's feet.
Those who act on it will ruin it.
Those who grasp it will lose it.
Therefore the sage:
Through non-action, he never fails.
Through not grasping, he never loses.
People often fail when their task is nearly complete.
Being as careful at the end as at the beginning,
Then there will be no failure.
Therefore the sage:
Desires to be without desire,
Does not value goods difficult to obtain,
Learns what others do not learn,
Returns to what others have passed by.
Thus he helps all things follow their natural way,
Yet dares not take action.

Chapter 65

gǔ zhī shàn wéi dào zhě
古 之 善 為 道 者
ancient of good-at practice way one-who

fēi yǐ míng mín
非 以 明 民
not by-means-of enlighten people

jiāng yǐ yú zhī
將 以 愚 之
will by-means-of simple them

mín zhī nán zhì
民 之 難 治
people of difficult govern

yǐ qí zhī duō
以 其 知 多
by-means-of their knowledge much

gù yǐ zhī zhì guó
故 以 知 治 國
therefore by-means-of knowledge govern country

guó zhī zéi
國 之 賊
country of thief

bù yǐ zhī zhì guó
不 以 知 治 國
not by-means-of knowledge govern country

guó zhī fú
國 之 福
country of fortune

zhī cǐ liǎng zhě yì jī shì
知 此 兩 者 亦 稽 式
know these two ones also examine pattern

cháng zhī jī shì
常 知 稽 式
always know examine pattern

shì wèi xuán dé
是 謂 玄 德
this called mysterious virtue

xuán dé shēn yī yuǎn yī
玄 德 深 矣 遠 矣
mysterious virtue deep indeed far indeed

yǔ	wù	fǎn	yī
與	物	反	矣
with	things	return	indeed

—	—	nǎi	zhì	dà	shùn
		乃	至	大	順
		then	reach	great	harmony

The ancient masters who were skilled in the Way
Did not use it to enlighten the people
But rather to keep them simple
People are difficult to govern
Because they have too much knowledge
Therefore using knowledge to rule the country
Is to rob the country
Not using knowledge to rule the country
Is the country's good fortune
Knowing these two principles serves as a model
Always knowing this pattern
This is called mysterious virtue
Mysterious virtue is deep and far-reaching
It returns with things to the great harmony
Only then is great harmony achieved

Chapter 66

jiāng hǎi suǒyī néng wéi bǎi gǔ wáng
 江 海 所以 能 為 百 谷 王
 river sea reason-why can become hundred valleys king
 zhě
 者
 is

yǐ qí shàn xià zhī
 以 其 善 下 之
 by-means-of their excel-at below them

gù néng wéi bǎi gǔ wáng
 故 能 為 百 谷 王
 therefore can become hundred valleys king

shì yǐ shèngrén
 是 以 聖人
 thus by-means-of sage

yù shàng mín
 欲 上 民
 wish above people

bì yǐ yán xià zhī
 必 以 言 下 之
 must by-means-of words below them

yù xiān mín
欲 先 民
wish ahead people

bì yǐ shēn hòu zhī
必 以 身 後 之
must by-means-of body behind them

shì yǐ shèng rén
是 以 聖 人
thus by-means-of sage person

chǔ shàng ér mín bù zhòng
處 上 而 民 不 重
dwell above yet people not burden

chǔ qián ér mín bù hài
處 前 而 民 不 害
dwell front yet people not harm

shìyǐ tiānxià lè tuī ér bù yàn
是 以 天 下 樂 推 而 不 厭
therefore world joy push yet not weary

yǐ qí bù zhēng
以 其 不 爭
by-means-of their not contend

gù	tiānxià	mò	néng	yǔ	zhī	zhēng
故	天下	莫	能	與	之	爭
therefore	world	none	can	with	them	contend

The reason rivers and seas can be kings of hundred valleys
Is because they excel at staying below them.
Therefore they can be kings of hundred valleys.
Thus when the sage
Wishes to be above the people
Must by words place himself below them
Wishes to be ahead of the people
Must by body place himself behind them
Thus when the sage
Dwells above yet people do not feel burdened
Stays ahead yet people are not harmed
Thus the world joyfully pushes them forward without wearying
Because they do not contend
Therefore none in the world can contend with them

Chapter 67

tiān xià jiē wèi wǒ — dà
天 下 皆 謂 我 — 大
heaven below all say I great

sì bù xiào
似 不 肖
seem not resemble

fú wéi bùxiào gù néng dà
夫 唯 不 肖 故 能 大
indeed only not-resemble therefore can great

ruò xiào
若 肖
if resemble

jiǔ yī qí xì yě
久 矣 其 細 也
long already its small indeed

fú wǒ yǒu sān bǎo
夫 我 有 三 寶
indeed I have three treasures

chí ér bǎo zhī
持 而 保 之
hold and protect them

yī yuē cí
一 曰 慈
one called compassion

èr yuē jiǎn
二 曰 儉
two called frugality

sān yuē bù gǎn wéi tiān xià xiān
三 曰 不 敢 為 天 下 先
three called not dare be heaven below first

cí gù néng yǒng
慈 故 能 勇
compassion therefore can brave

jiǎn gù néng guǎng
儉 故 能 廣
frugality therefore can broad

bù gǎn wéi tiān xià xiān
不 敢 為 天 下 先
not dare be heaven below first

gù	néng	chéng	qì	zhǎng
故	能	成	器	長
therefore	can	become	vessel	leader

jīn	shě	cí	qiě	yǒng
今	舍	慈	且	勇
now	abandon	compassion	and	brave

shě	jiǎn	qiě	guǎng
舍	儉	且	廣
abandon	frugality	and	broad

shě	hòu	qiě	xiān
舍	後	且	先
abandon	behind	and	first

sǐ	yǐ
死	矣
death	indeed

fú	cí	yǐ	zhàn	zé	shèng
夫	慈	以	戰	則	勝
indeed	compassion	by-means-of	battle	then	victory

yǐ	shǒu	zé	gù
以	守	則	固
by-means-of	defend	then	firm

tiān jiāng jiù zhī
天 將 救 之
heaven will save it

yǐ cí wèi zhī
以 慈 衛 之
by-means-of compassion guard it

All under heaven say I am great while seeming unlike it.
Appearing unlike greatness.
Precisely because of not resembling greatness, one can be truly great.
Were I to resemble greatness...
Long indeed would I have remained small.
Indeed, I have three treasures.
Hold them and protect them.
The first is called compassion.
The second is called frugality.
The third is called not daring to be ahead of all under heaven.
Through compassion, one can be courageous.
Through frugality, one can be generous.
Not daring to be ahead of all under heaven.
Therefore can become a perfected vessel and leader.
Now abandoning compassion for courage.
Abandoning frugality for expansion.
Abandoning the rear to go ahead.
Death indeed!
Indeed, with compassion, in battle one is victorious.
In defense, one is secure.
Heaven will save.
With compassion protect it.

Chapter 68

shàn	wéi	shì	zhě	bù	wǔ
善	為	士	者	不	武
good-at	act-as	warrior	one-who	not	martial

shàn	zhàn	zhě	bù	nù
善	戰	者	不	怒
good-at	battle	one-who	not	anger

shàn	shèng	dí	zhě	bù	yǔ
善	勝	敵	者	不	與
good-at	defeat	enemy	one-who	not	engage

shàn	yòng	rén	zhě	wéi	zhī	xià
善	用	人	者	為	之	下
good-at	use	people	one-who	act-as	them	below

shì	wèi	bù	zhēng	zhī	dé
是	謂	不	爭	之	德
this	called	non	contention	of	virtue

shì	wèi	yòng	rén	zhī	lì
是	謂	用	人	之	力
this	called	use	people	of	strength

shì	wèi	pèi	tiān	gǔ	zhī	jí	
是	謂	配	天	古	之	極	也
this	called	match	heaven	ancient	of	ultimate	indeed

The best warrior does not display martial prowess.
The best fighter never becomes angry.
The best conqueror does not engage the enemy.
The best employer of people places themselves below others.
This is called the virtue of non-contention.
This is called using the strength of others.
This is called matching the ancient ultimate principle of heaven.

Chapter 69

yòng bīng yǒu yán
用兵 有 言
use-military have saying

wú bù gǎn wéi zhǔ ér wéi kè
吾 不 敢 為 主 而 為 客
I not dare act-as host but act-as guest

bù gǎn jìn cùn ér tuì chǐ
不 敢 進 寸 而 退 尺
not dare advance inch but retreat foot

shì wèi xíng wú xíng
是 謂 行 無 行
this called march without marching

rǎng wú bì
攘 無 臂
roll-up without arms

rēng wú dí
扔 無 敵
grasp without enemy

zhí	wú	bīng
執	無	兵
hold	without	troops

huò	mò	dà	yú	qīng	dí
禍	莫	大	於	輕	敵
disaster	none	greater	than	treat-lightly	enemy

qīng	dí	jī	sàng	wú	bǎo
輕	敵	幾	喪	吾	寶
treat-lightly	enemy	nearly	lose	my	treasure

gù	kàng	bīng	xiāng	ruò
故	抗	兵	相	若
therefore	oppose	armies	mutually	like

zé	āi	zhě	shèng	yī
則	哀	者	勝	矣
then	sorrowful	one	victory	indeed

In military affairs, there is a saying:
I dare not be the host, but rather be the guest.
I dare not advance an inch, but retreat a foot.
This is called marching without marching.
Rolling up sleeves without arms.
Grasping without weapons.
Confronting without troops.
No disaster is greater than underestimating the enemy.
Underestimating the enemy nearly loses my treasure.
Therefore when armies oppose each other,
The sorrowful one will be victorious.

Chapter 70

wú yán shèn yì zhī
吾 言 甚 易 知
I words very easy understand

shèn yì xíng
甚 易 行
very easy practice

ér tiān-xià mò zhī néng zhī
而 天 下 莫 之 能 知
yet under-heaven none it can understand

mò zhī néng xíng
莫 之 能 行
none it can practice

yán yǒu zōng
言 有 宗
words have source

shì yǒu jūn
事 有 君
affairs have ruler

fú wéi wú zhī
夫 唯 無 知
indeed only not understand

shì-yǐ bù wǒ zhī
是以 不 我 知
therefore not me understand

zhī wǒ zhě xī
知 我 者 希
understand me those-who rare

zé wǒ zhě guì yī
則 我 者 貴 矣
then I one precious indeed

shì-yǐ shèng-rén
是以 聖人
therefore sage

pī hè ér huái yù
被 褐 而 懷 玉
wear coarse-cloth yet embrace jade

My words are very easy to understand.
Very easy to practice.
Yet under heaven none can understand them.
None can practice them.
Words have their source.
Affairs have their ruler.
It is only through not understanding.
Therefore they do not understand me.
Those who understand me are few.
Thus I am valued.
Therefore the sage
Wears coarse cloth while embracing jade within.

Chapter 71

zhī	bù	zhī	shàng	yī
知	不	知	尚	矣
know	not	know	highest	indeed

bù	zhī	zhī	bìng	yī
不	知	知	病	矣
not	know	know	illness	indeed

fú	wéi	bìng	bìng
夫	唯	病	病
indeed	only	illness	illness

shì	yǐ	bù	bìng
是	以	不	病
this	by-means-of	not	illness

shèng	rén	bù	bìng
聖	人	不	病
sage	person	not	illness

yǐ	qí	bìng	bìng
以	其	病	病
by-means-of	his	illness	illness

shì	yǐ	bù	bìng
是	以	不	病
this	by-means-of	not	illness

To know what one does not know is highest.
Not knowing what one knows is affliction.
Indeed, it is by recognizing affliction as affliction,
That one is free from affliction.
The sage is free from affliction.
Because he recognizes affliction as affliction,
Therefore he is free from affliction.

Chapter 72

mín	bù	wèi	wēi
民	不	畏	威
people	not	fear	authority

zé	dà	wēi	zhì	yī
則	大	威	至	矣
then	great	authority	arrive	indeed

wú	xiá	qí	suǒ	jū
無	狎	其	所	居
do-not	restrict	their	place	dwell

wú	yàn	qí	suǒ	shēng
無	厭	其	所	生
do-not	weary	their	that-which	live

fú	wéi	bù	yàn
夫	唯	不	厭
indeed	only	not	oppress

shì	yǐ	bù	yàn
是	以	不	厭
this	by-means-of	not	weary

shì	yǐ	shèng	rén
是	以	聖	人
this	by-means-of	sage	person

zì	zhī	bù	zì	xiàn
自	知	不	自	見
self	know	not	self	display

zì	ài	bù	zì	guì
自	愛	不	自	貴
self	love	not	self	value

gù	qù	bǐ	qǔ	cǐ
故	去	彼	取	此
therefore	reject	that	choose	this

When people do not fear authority,
Then great authority will arrive indeed.
Do not restrict where they dwell,
Do not weary them in their livelihood.
It is because you do not oppress them,
Therefore they will not be wearied.
Therefore the sage
Knows himself but does not display himself.
Loves himself but does not exalt himself.
Therefore he rejects that and chooses this.

Chapter 73

yǒng yú gǎn
勇 於 敢
brave in dare

zé shā
則 殺
then kill

yǒng yú bù gǎn
勇 於 不 敢
brave in not dare

zé huó
則 活
then live

cǐ liǎng zhě huò lì huò hài
此 兩 者 或 利 或 害
these two ones perhaps benefit perhaps harm

tiān zhī suǒ wù shú zhī qí gù
天 之 所 惡 孰 知 其 故
heaven of that-which detest who know its reason

shì yǐ shèng rén yóu nán zhī
是 以 聖 人 猶 難 之
this by-means-of sage person still difficult it

tiān zhī dào
天 之 道
heaven of way

bù zhēng ér shàn shèng
不 爭 而 善 勝
not contend yet good-at prevail

bù yán ér shàn yīng
不 言 而 善 應
not speak yet good-at respond

bù zhào ér zì lái
不 召 而 自 來
not summon yet self come

chán rán ér shàn móu
縉 然 而 善 謀
slow thus yet good-at plan

tiān wǎng huī huī
天 網 恢 恢
heaven net vast vast

shū	ér	bù	shī
疏	而	不	失
loose	yet	not	lose

To be brave in daring leads to death.
Then there is killing.
To be brave in not daring leads to life.
Then there is life.
Of these two, one brings benefit, one brings harm.
That which Heaven abhors - who knows the reason?
Thus even the sage finds this difficult.
The Way of Heaven:
Not contending, yet skillfully prevailing.
Not speaking, yet skillfully responding.
Not summoned, yet coming of itself.
Unhurried, yet skillfully planning.
Heaven's net is vast,
Loosely meshed, yet nothing slips through.

Chapter 74

mín bù wèi sǐ
民 不 畏 死
people not fear death

nài hé yǐ sǐ jù zhī
奈 何 以 死 懼 之
how what by-means-of death frighten them

ruò shǐ mǐn cháng wèi sǐ
若 使 民 常 畏 死
if cause people always fear death

ér wéi qí zhě wú dé zhí ér shā
而 為 奇 者 吾 得 執 而 殺
and do strange ones I could seize and kill
zhī
之
them

shú gǎn
孰 敢
who dare

cháng yǒu sī shā zhě
常 有 司 殺 者 —
always have officer kill one

fú	dài	sī	shā	zhě	shā
夫	代	司	殺	者	殺
now	replace	officer	kill	one	kill

shì	wèi	dài	dà	jiàng	zhuó
是	謂	代	大	匠	斲
this	called	replace	great	craftsman	cut

fú	dài	dà	jiàng	zhuó	zhě
夫	代	大	匠	斲	者
now	replace	great	craftsman	cut	one

xī	—	bù	shāng	qí	shǒu	yī
希	—	不	傷	其	手	矣
rare		not	harm	one's	hand	indeed

The people do not fear death.
How then can death be used to frighten them?
If the people were made to constantly fear death,
And I could seize and execute those who do strange things,
Who would dare?
There is always an official executioner.
Now, to kill in place of the executioner,
This is like cutting in place of the master carpenter.
One who cuts in place of the master carpenter,
Rarely escapes injuring their own hands.

Chapter 75

mín zhī jī
民 之 饑
people of hungry

yǐ qí shàng shí shuì zhī duō
以 其 上 食 稅 之 多
by-means-of their above eat tax of much

shì yǐ jī
是 以 饑
this therefore hungry

mín zhī nán zhì
民 之 難 治
people of difficult govern

yǐ qí shàng zhī yǒu wéi
以 其 上 之 有 為
by-means-of their above of have do

shì yǐ nán zhì
是 以 難 治
this therefore difficult govern

mín zhī qīng sǐ
民 之 輕 死
people of light death

yǐ qí qiú shēng zhī hòu
以 其 求 生 之 厚
by-means-of their seek life of excessive

shì yǐ qīng sǐ
是 以 輕 死
this therefore light death

fú wéi wú yǐ shēng wéi zhě
夫 唯 無 以 生 為 者
indeed only without by-means-of life do one-who

shì xián yú guì shēng
是 賢 於 貴 生
this worthy than value life

When the people are hungry...
It is because their rulers consume too much in taxes.
Thus they are hungry.
When the people are difficult to govern...
It is because their rulers interfere too much.
Thus they are difficult to govern.
When the people take death lightly...
It is because they seek too much life.
Thus they take death lightly.
Only the one who does not strive after life...
Is wiser than those who value life too dearly.

Chapter 76

rén zhī shēng yě róu ruò
人 之 生 也 柔 弱
person of live indeed soft weak

qí sǐ yě jiān qiáng
其 死 也 堅 強
their die indeed hard strong

wàn wù cǎo mù zhī shēng yě róu cuì
萬 物 草 木 之 生 也 柔 脆
ten-thousand things grass tree of live indeed soft fragile

qí sǐ yě kū gāo
其 死 也 枯 槁
their die indeed withered dried

gù jiān qiáng zhě sǐ zhī tú
故 堅 強 者 死 之 徒
therefore hard strong one-who death of companion

róu ruò zhě shēng zhī tú
柔 弱 者 生 之 徒
soft weak one-who life of companion

shì	yǐ	bīng	qiáng	zé	bù	shèng
是	以	兵	強	則	不	勝
this	by-means-of	weapon	strong	then	not	prevail

mù	qiáng	zé	bīng
木	強	則	兵
tree	strong	then	weapon

qiáng	dà	chù	xià
強	大	處	下
strong	great	dwel	below

róu	ruò	chù	shàng
柔	弱	處	上
soft	weak	dwel	above

When people are born, they are soft and weak.
At death, they are hard and strong.
When plants and trees are born, they are soft and fragile.
At death, they are withered and dry.
Thus, that which is hard and strong is a companion of death.
That which is soft and weak is a companion of life.
Therefore, when an army is strong, it will not prevail.
When a tree is strong, it will be cut down.
The strong and great dwell below.
The soft and weak dwell above.

Chapter 77

tiān zhī dào qí yóu zhāng gōng yǔ
天 之 道 其 猶 張 弓 與
heaven of way it like draw bow indeed

gāo zhě yì zhī
高 者 抑 之
high that-which press-down it

xià zhě jǔ zhī
下 者 舉 之
low that-which lift it

yǒu yú zhě sǔn zhī
有 餘 者 損 之
have excess that-which reduce it

bù zú zhě bǔ zhī
不 足 者 補 之
not sufficient that-which supplement it

tiān zhī dào
天 之 道
heaven of way

sūn yǒu yú ér bǔ bù zú
損 有 餘 而 補 不 足
reduce have excess and supplement not sufficient

rén zhī dào zé bù rán
人 之 道 則 不 然
human of way then not so

sūn bù zú yǐ fèng yǒu yú
損 不 足 以 奉 有 餘
reduce not sufficient by-means-of serve have excess

shú néng yǒu yú ér fèng yú tiān xià
孰 能 有 餘 而 奉 於 天 下
who can have excess and serve to heaven below

wéi yǒu dào zhě
唯 有 道 者
only have way one

shì yǐ shèng rén
是 以 聖 人
this therefore sage person

wéi ér bù shì
為 而 不 恃
act yet not rely-on

gōng	chéng	ér	bù	chǔ
功	成	而	不	處
merit	complete	yet	not	dwell

qí	bù	yù	xiàn	xián
其	不	欲	見	賢
their	not	desire	show	worthy

The way of Heaven is like drawing a bow:
What is high, it brings down.
What is low, it raises up.
From those with excess, it takes away.
To those lacking, it adds.
The way of Heaven:
Reduces excess and supplements insufficiency.
The way of humans is not thus:
They take from those who lack to serve those who have excess.
Who can take their excess and offer it to the world?
Only one who possesses the Way.
Therefore the sage:
Acts but does not rely on it.
Achieves merit but does not dwell on it.
They do not wish to display their wisdom.

Chapter 78

tiān	xià	mò	róuruò	yú	shuǐ
天	下	莫	柔弱	於	水
heaven	below	none	soft-weak	than	water

ér	gōng	jiānqiáng	zhě
而	攻	堅強	者
yet	attack	hard-strong	one

mò	zhī	néng	shèng
莫	之	能	勝
none	it	can	surpass

yǐ	qí	wú	yǐ	yì	zhī
以	其	無	以	易	之
by-means-of	its	nothing	by-means-of	change	it

ruò	zhī	shèng	qiáng
弱	之	勝	強
weak	possessive	overcome	strong

róu	zhī	shèng	gāng
柔	之	勝	剛
soft	possessive	overcome	hard

tiān	xià	mò	bù	zhī
天	下	莫	不	知
heaven	below	none	not	know

mò	néng	xíng
莫	能	行
none	can	practice

shì	yǐ	shèng	rén	yún
是	以	聖	人	云
this	therefore	sage	person	say

shòu	guó	zhī	gòu
受	國	之	垢
receive	state	of	filth

shì	wèi	shèjì	zhī	zhǔ
是	謂	社稷	之	主
this	called	state-altars	of	master

shòu	guó	zhī	búxiáng
受	國	之	不祥
receive	state	of	misfortune

shì	wèi	tiān	xià	zhī	wáng
是	謂	天	下	之	王
this	called	heaven	below	of	king

zhèng
正
correct

yán
言
words

ruò
若
like

fǎn
反
opposite

Nothing in the world is softer and weaker than water.
Yet in attacking the firm and strong.
Nothing can surpass it.
Because nothing can take its place.
The weak overcomes the strong.
The soft overcomes the hard.
Everyone in the world knows this.
Yet none can put it into practice.
Therefore the sage says:
One who accepts the state's filth
Is called the master of the state altars.
One who bears the state's misfortunes
Is called the king of all under heaven.
True words seem paradoxical.

Chapter 79

hé dà yuàn
和 大 怨
reconcile great resentment

bì yǒu yú yuàn
必 有 餘 怨
must have remaining resentment

ān kě yǐ wéi shàn
安 可 以 為 善
how can by-means-of consider good

shì yǐ shèng rén
是 以 聖 人
this by-means-of sage person

zhí zuǒ qì
執 左 契
hold left contract

ér bù zé yú rén
而 不 責 於 人
yet not demand from person

	yǒu	dé	sī	qì
故	有	德	司	契
therefore	have	virtue	manage	contract

wú	dé	sī	chè
無	德	司	徹
without	virtue	manage	taxation

tiān	dào	wú	qīn
天	道	無	親
heaven	way	without	favorites

cháng	yǔ	shàn	rén
常	與	善	人
constant	with	good	person

In reconciling great resentment
There must remain some resentment.
How can this be considered good?
Therefore the sage
Holds the left side of the contract
And does not demand from others
Therefore, those with virtue oversee contracts
Those without virtue oversee taxation
The Way of Heaven has no favorites
It constantly sides with the good person

Chapter 80

xiǎo	guó	guǎ	mín
小	國	寡	民
small	state	few	people

shǐ	yǒu	shí-bǎi	zhī	qì	ér	bù	yòng
使	有	什伯	之	器	而	不	用
let	have	tens-and-hundreds	of	tools	yet	not	use

shǐ	mín	zhòng	sǐ	ér	bù	yuǎn	xí
使	民	重	死	而	不	遠	徙
let	people	heavy	death	yet	not	far	migrate

suī	yǒu	zhōu-yú	wú	suǒ	chéng	zhī
雖	有	舟輿	無	所	乘	之
although	have	boats-and-carriages	no	place	ride	them

suī	yǒu	jiǎ-bīng	wú	suǒ	chén	zhī
雖	有	甲兵	無	所	陳	之
although	have	armor-and-weapons	no	place	display	them

shǐ	mín	fù	jié	shéng	ér	yòng	zhī
使	民	復	結	繩	而	用	之
let	people	return	tie	rope	and	use	it

gān	qí	shí
甘	其	食
sweet	their	food

měi	qí	fú
美	其	服
beautiful	their	clothes

ān	qí	jū
安	其	居
peaceful	their	dwelling

lè	qí	sù
樂	其	俗
delight	their	customs

lín	guó	xiāng	wàng
鄰	國	相	望
neighboring	states	mutually	gaze

jī	quǎn	zhī	shēng	xiāng	wén
雞	犬	之	聲	相	聞
rooster	dog	of	sound	mutually	hear

mín	zhì	lǎo	sǐ
民	至	老	死
people	until	old	die

bù	xiāng	wǎng	lái
不	相	往	來
not	mutually	go	come

A small state with few people:
Though they have tools for tens and hundreds, they do not use them.
Let the people regard death seriously and not migrate far.
Although they have boats and carriages, they have nowhere to ride them.
Although they have armor and weapons, they have nowhere to display them.
Let the people return to using knotted ropes.
They find their food sweet.
They find their clothes beautiful.
They are peaceful in their dwellings.
They delight in their customs.
Neighboring states might be within sight of each other.
The sounds of roosters and dogs can be heard from one to another.
The people grow old and die.
Yet they do not visit one another.

Chapter 81

xìn	yán	bù	měi
信	言	不	美
truthful	words	not	beautiful

měi	yán	bù	xìn
美	言	不	信
beautiful	words	not	truthful

shàn	zhě	bù	biàn
善	者	不	辯
good	one-who	not	argue

biàn	zhě	bù	shàn
辯	者	不	善
argue	one-who	not	good

zhī	zhě	bù	bó
知	者	不	博
wise	one-who	not	broad-learning

bó	zhě	bù	zhī
博	者	不	知
broad-learning	one-who	not	wise

shèng rén bù jī
聖 人 不 積
sage person not accumulate

jì yǐ wéi rén jì yù yǒu
既 以 為 人 己 愈 有
already by-means-of do-for others self more have

jì yǐ yǔ rén jì yù duō
既 以 與 人 己 愈 多
already by-means-of give others self more abundant

tiān zhī dào lì ér bù hài
天 之 道 利 而 不 害
heaven of way benefit yet not harm

shèng rén zhī dào wéi ér bù zhēng
聖 人 之 道 為 而 不 爭
sage person of way act yet not contend

Truthful words are not beautiful.
Beautiful words are not truthful.
The good are not argumentative.
The argumentative are not good.
The wise are not widely learned.
The widely learned are not wise.
The sage does not accumulate.
Having used it for others, one has even more.
Having given to others, one has even greater abundance.
The Way of Heaven benefits and does not harm.
The Way of the sage acts without contention.

